

Dear Tomorrow, Dear Past

– A Novella

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I feel a long and unresolved desire
For that serene and solemn land of ghosts,
It quivers now, like an Aeolian lyre,
My stuttering verse, with its uncertain notes,
A shudder takes me: tear on tear, entire,
The firm heart feels weakened and remote:
What I possess seems far away from me,
And what is gone becomes reality.

J.W. Goethe, *Faust*,
Translated by A. S. Kline

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PART I

That day, when the bell for the end of class echoed through the corridors, Xie Huai-jin had just crafted the last phrase of the lecture. Having spent three years as a student in this school in the past, she had mastered the timing of the bells, almost as if it were ingrained in her bones.

Huai-jin took a moment to tidy up her desk—arranging the chalk neatly, wiping the dust from the textbooks and lesson plans with her handkerchief, then folding them neatly and holding them close as she walked out of the classroom. She noticed a student waiting for her in the hallway.

She remembered this girl was named Li Ying-Zi.

Though Huai-jin had only been teaching this class as a temporary Chinese language instructor for a short time, this girl had left a deep impression on her. In class, she was always an active participant, raising her hand for almost every question. When she was called on to give an answer, her answer, though not necessarily perfect, was always reflective of her nuanced observation and deep thoughts. In essays, her lines were filled with a poetic spirit, and her hand-writing was clear and pleasing.

Despite the strong impression, Huai-jin couldn't recall any significant interaction between them.

Huai-jin wanted to ask why she was here, but the girl had already started to speak:

“Xie *Lao-shi*, your last name is the 'xie' that means thanks, right?”

“Yes...?” Huai-jin was a bit lost — she had given an introduction when the class started.

“What is your full name?” asked the girl.

An intrusive but not offensive question. Though she was unsure of the girl's intention, Huai-jin answered her question: “My name is Xie Huai-jin. 'Huai' as embrace and hold; 'jin' with the radical of jade¹.”

“So, it is Huai-jin from *Huai Jin Wo Yu*².”

“Correct,” Huai-jin smiled in response. “You know quite a lot.” When was the last time someone discussed the meaning of her name? She could barely remember. She'd almost forgotten how she got this name.

“My *Sao-sao*³ told me.” The girl responded proudly, “I know that both 'Huai jin' and 'Wo yu' means carrying jade.”

As Huai-jin looked at the neatly braided hair of the girl, tied with a vivid red ribbon, she vaguely recalled someone from her past. In that instant, a suspicion that had been simmering deep within Huai-jin's heart began to surface. She tried to grasp the flash of inspiration: “Your *Sao-sao*?”

“Yes, my *Sao-sao*,” said the girl. “Her name is Wang Wo-yu.”

Instantly, an image rose before Huai-jin's eyes—Wo-yu from an evening ten years ago—when Huai-jin went to her place in town to look for her. Wo-yu's family lived on the first floor. She stood in front of the door for a while, staring at the places where the paint had peeled off the old wooden door, mentally preparing herself, and then she knocked. Once. Twice. It seemed that she knocked for a long while, but she couldn't remember exactly how many times she knocked. She remembered that the weather was a bit hot and that her hands were sweating despite the twist of numbness and nervousness she felt. Huai-jin was, at one moment, not sure if she really wanted to see Wo-yu because when she thought about the possibility of no one at home; she felt a sense of relief. Then she heard the footsteps approaching—just as she was turning to leave.

¹ “王”: though looks like 王 (king), it signifies 玉(jade).

² “怀瑾握瑜”: Chinese idiom. both 瑾 and 瑜 are types of jade, and 怀、握 signifies holding. Literally it means holding jade; metaphorically it means (someone) having virtues.

³ Sao: 嫂, sister-in-law. Specifically, the wife of one's elder brother.

It wasn't Wo-yu. It was her mom, a middle-aged woman in whose face she could see the contour of Wo-yu (but made her feel so different at the same time). The middle-aged woman asked: "Were you knocking?"

"Ah—yes." She quickly withdrew herself from her complicated emotions, trying to behave as properly as possible. "*A-yi*⁴—may I ask—is Wo-yu at home?"

"Who?" The woman looked confused.

Huai-jin repeated mechanically, her brain blank: "Wo-yu, Wang Wo-yu."

"Wang..."

She then thought she might have come to the wrong door, as everything around her seemed so unfamiliar and surreal, and she couldn't connect them to Wo-yu despite the fact that they hadn't seen each other for a long while.

But then the woman reacted: "Oh, you mean Pan-di⁵. She's at home." She quickly sized up Huai-jin and suddenly recognized her: "Oh, it's you. Sure, I can get her here." And she added, "Make your conversation quick. She's different. She still has work to do."

Maybe she didn't say that exactly, but Huai-jin was sure that she said something similar to "She's different"—which pricked her heart. When had they become different? She had been to this apartment before, and then she felt Wo-yu and she were on the one side against the whole world. But now, she felt that Wo-yu had joined her mother, and she was alone on the other side.

The woman raised her voice to call Wo-yu: "Pan-di, Pan-di, your old school-mate is looking for you."

Huai-jin stayed at the door, waiting anxiously.

Then Wo-yu came. The woman slightly tilted her head and raised her eyebrows to signal Huai-jin's presence to her daughter. Then she left, leaving two girls alone.

Now Wo-yu was right there in front of Huai-jin. She still appeared the same with two braids and the dress she always wore before. But she made Huai-jin feel unfamiliar, especially when she visibly paused at a certain distance, seemingly not sure if she should continue.

"Huai-jin." Said Wo-yu.

She stood in front of Huai-jin, her dark eyes reflecting the fragmented light of the setting sun. At that moment, Huai-jin realized that the Wo-yu in front of her was not the Wo-yu she

⁴ A-yi: 阿姨, auntie, a name for aunt-aged elders. 姨 refers to mother's sisters.

⁵ Pan-di: 盼(hope for)弟(little brother), still a common given name for girl in the rural area today.

knew. In the past, Wo-yu called her name millions of times, but she knew that this time was different because now she smiled as light as the wind running through the leaves.

Huai-jin's earliest memory of truly living began with her first encounter with Wo-yu. In a way, she hadn't even been Huai-jin yet until they met.

Huai-jin was born in a village of southeastern China before New China was founded. She lost her mother almost as soon as she was born, left behind with one older sister and two older brothers. When marrying the second wife, her father kept her two brothers, as the men were crucial human resources in the countryside. But to please his new wife, he sent away two useless daughters. Huai-jin's sister was disabled, so she wasn't accepted locally. According to the gossip, she was taken to the town and likely adopted by some foreigners with blue eyes and blonde hair. But no one could verify that. In this era with underdeveloped communication technology, Huai-jin had no way to know what eventually became of her. She never saw her sister again.

Huai-jin shared the fate of many other girls of her generation; she was sent to a family residing in the neighboring village as an adopted daughter. The father, with the family name Lin, had three sons and another adopted daughter. “Adopted daughter” at this time was an euphemism for *Tong-yang-xi*⁶, Which Huai-jin figured out later as she grew up. Most of the time, the adopted daughters were married to the sons in the family. Huai-jin was an exception. The third son in the Lin household died at a young age before she had any clear memory, so she was indeed raised like a daughter.

In the countryside, there wasn't much difference between raising a daughter or a daughter-in-law. Although every family dedicated their food and resources to the male laborers, only the cruel people mistreated their girls. In the farming season, everyone over four years old had to labor. Unlike the ladies in the landlord family where no one needed to farm, in a farming family, even the favorite girl cannot be idle.

Back then, Huai-jin wasn't Huai-jin yet. The people around called her “A-Xie” in the same way that they called her adopted sister—born in the family Zhang— “A-Zhang”. Closer

⁶ Tong-yang-xi: 童养媳, child bride; a girl taken into the family as a daughter-in-law-to-be.

people, including her adopted parents, called her by her nickname “Lan-zi,⁷” because she was sent to Lin from Xie in a bamboo basket.

Huai-jin's early childhood was simple and dull. In her memory, she couldn't think of much difference between her and her adopted sister. Neither of them was a “lazy girl”; The adults in the village considered them as exemplary kids. She could only recall that when they were young, compared to her taciturn and demure sister, she was more clever and lively, knowing how to please the elders with speech and deeds. She always had a keen sense of when she could wield her childish innocence to utter naive words that would make the adults laugh, and when it was time to act mature and reliable, offering help to the adults. When they were very young, her sister and her, despite their different personalities, were best friends and playmates. Had their surrounding environment remained the same as their mother's and grandmother's, they would have stayed close forever. A-Zhang would marry the second brother in the household, and she, because of the death of her designated husband, would marry somewhere close. The sisters would hover over each other and share a similar lifestyle throughout their whole lives.

However, before Huai-jin's hair grew white, she hardly saw her sister, with whom she was so close in early childhood. They kept a good relationship, but they interacted just like other relatives. It seemed that from a certain moment, they were no longer living in the same world.

It took a long time for Huai-jin to realize that the origin of everything that mattered to her was something that their fathers never had—and even their generation could not really have: choices in life.

On this land, Huai-jin's ancestors made a living with farming. Most of the people never travelled anywhere further than the Town. Generations repeated similar stories. They didn't care about the world outside, focusing on the mundane trivias and local gossip. Even in the hardest time in the '40s, when the whole nation was struggling and fighting in the fatal war, as a remote place without strategic significance, her village was hardly impacted. Nevertheless, everything

⁷ Lan-zi: 篮子, basket.

changed in the winter of a new decade, and from then on, the fate of that land and its people were carried on the train of history, rapidly rolling forward. Nothing was the same again.

When she grew up, Huai-jin could barely remember how that life-changing revolution began. She remembered the loud sounds and strong colors with the bustling crowd everywhere. The villagers made sounds with cymbals and drums, or probably iron pots; the children held up the red flags, marching from village to village. Many years later, Huai-jin realized that this might have been a celebration of land reformation. Yet she wasn't totally sure. As a kid, she treated it as one of the big events, like the spring and mid-autumn festivals every year or weddings and funerals of neighbors.

As a poor farming family who didn't own any land, the Lins should have enjoyed the reform as a total blessing. Indeed, they did benefit from the new land policy. Before then, Huai-jin's adopted father was a tenant for his cousin. After the reformation, they owned some land for the first time. Purely from the economic perspective, they had a better life.

However, politically, they were evaluated as rich farmers rather than poor farmers, who enjoyed the best political standings and welfare. Before Huai-jin understood what had happened, the story behind had already spread around the village as gossip. The adults looked at the Lin children with sympathetic eyes, while the children, who spoke without understanding the weight of their words, mimicked adults' ways to comment on Huai-jin's adopted father's "stupidness" but right to her face.

As the story went, Lin's cousin—also his landlord—travelled away when he could tell the reformation was coming, asking Lin to help keep his land. At the same time, he tricked her adopted father into using the land so that he would get evaluated as a landlord—which was surely a good *Cheng-fen*⁸ according to this cousin. Many years later, Huai-jin found this deception self-evident; but her father, who stayed in his village for his whole life without any chances to gain more perspectives, fell right into the trap.

Huai-jin then was only a kid without any chance to get involved in a big thing like this. By the time she knew what had happened, her father's silly mistake was already a widespread joke. When the evaluators from the town went to Lin, he badgered them to evaluate him as a

⁸ *Cheng-fen*: 成分, literally means composition, politically refers to people's background, classes, and political standing. It was once a part of the Chinese political system; North Korea still uses it today.

landlord, regardless of their explanation. Recognizing that his hands must work at the usual labors, they evaluated him as a rich farmer instead of the landlord.

Much later, when “rich farmer” was inscribed on her identification materials, to follow her in her life journey, Huai-jin knew that they should have been evaluated as poor farmers. Her father must have figured it out too, as he later always appeared to be taciturn and indecisive. He neither supported nor opposed Huai-jin's life choices—which most farmers couldn't understand. Huai-jin thought it may have been due to his sense of guilt and remorse for how his ignorant action affected the family.

Later, in difficult times, when Huai-jin was alone, helpless, she couldn't tell if she held a complaint against her father in her heart. But eventually she realized that she forgave him, as he not only raised her but also let her leave. She left her village as a *Tong-yang-xi*.

Huai-jin still remembered the first time she met Chen *Lao-shi*. She was so decently dressed it was as if she was from another world. Holding a few textbooks, she knocked open Lin's door. At the time, Huai-jin was still short and petite. She saw that Chen *Lao-shi's* dress was tidy, without any patches. When she looked down, she saw a pair of clean shoes.

In the past, schooling had been something too far from her. Education was something expensive and hardly useful. Only the rich landlords could afford considering such a risky gamble. Keeping livestock and giving birth to more children promised more dependable rewards. In the “old society” in the past, where the land transaction wasn't forbidden—if a family had money, they would invest it on purchasing lands and hiring tenants rather than the ethereal education.

But this time, it was for free.

Chen *Lao-shi* mentioned contributing to the new nation and things like literacy rate and poverty alleviation, but Huai-jin's adopted parents only remembered one piece of information: elementary school education was free.

Huai-jin vaguely remembered—as she was at the scene, maybe somewhere in the house or at the front door—that Chen *Lao-shi* gently caressed her hair: “This is your little one, right?

Can't you tell from her eyes how clever she is? Small like this, she can not do much work, right? She can't really help much with farming, right? If she goes to school, she can still do chores at night. In the most busy farming season, we will also let them off to help out with their family. But if she could finish half of elementary school and be able to read the basic characters, she would have more advantages when she looks for a job in the town. If she could go further, she might even have a chance to do administrative work for the government. I visited a few families before I came to your house, and they were all going to send their kids to elementary school."

While her parents were still hesitating, Chen *Lao-shi* looked at her and asked softly: "Girl, do you want to go to school?"

Her eyes, filled with tenderness and care, shone on Huai-jin like a gentle rosy glow in the early morning. Feeling so drawn to such a mother-like elder, she blurted out: "Yes!"

Many years later, Huai-jin could barely recall her real feeling then—education for her was still such a vague, vague thing. Even on that afternoon, when she answered "yes" to Chen *Lao-shi*, everything for her was still surreal. Neither could she remember the details of the family discussion later that night although she knew even at that moment that it was a significant decision.

The elementary school sat at a crossroads between a few villages, less than half an hour's walk from home. The classroom was a newly built single-story adobe house, one of the most refined buildings in the area. There weren't as many kids in the school as Chen *Lao-shi* had implied. Huai-jin's eldest brother was older and considered sitting in the classroom and learning everything from the beginning with little kids as shameful, so the parents only required their second son to go.. Huai-jin's adopted sister *A-Zhang* had no opinions of her own; seeing two peer siblings go, she ended up going with them. All three started at Grade one.

The whole school had only two teachers with Chen *Lao-shi* being one of them. She was a widow of an honored soldier. She had only one son, currently a boarding high schooler in town. She didn't want to sit on her military welfare alone at home. Working in a countryside school was her way to follow her husband and make contributions to this newly built country and the people

on the land. Because of her background, although she resided alone near the countryside as a single woman, people had reverence for her and didn't dare to bully her.

She taught grade one both Chinese and math. When she taught characters, she wrote on the blackboard in the front of the classroom with grey chalk, and the students, without pens and pencils, tried to mimic her stroke with an index finger on the table. In the morning, they reviewed characters and did math; in the afternoon, they learned new characters. The school dismissed them in the very early afternoon, so they could help out with family.

Before Huai-jin's first math class, she didn't know that numbers could be a subject. In the countryside, they counted numbers with fingers. As they hardly had anything more than the number of fingers, they didn't have the opportunity and didn't need to use big numbers. Although there were only ten Arabic numbers, they were brand new for Huai-jin. When the first class was over, the teacher assigned some textbook exercises to let students think. Huai-jin stared at her textbooks, confused: "Wait, we didn't learn this."

"Which question? They are all additions under ten. We learned that today." It was a girl nearby who answered. Her hair was braided in two with red bands.

So Huai-jin walked to her with her textbooks and pointed out the confusion to her: "Look at this symbol; we didn't talk about that."

The girl said: "This is number four."

"Ah?" Huai-jin was stunned for a second, looking at the blackboard. "It is different from what the teacher told us. See, the 4 has two strokes on the blackboard."

The girl giggled, exhibiting with her fingers on the desk: "They are the same. Look, if you write these two strokes close enough, it is identical to the printed ones in the textbook, right?"

Huai-jin got it right away. Two girls naturally slipped into conversation.

The girl resided in the neighboring village with her *Jie-jie*⁹ and *Da-bo*¹⁰. Her parents and *Di-di*¹¹ dwelled in town. Her father was a worker, and her mother was a seamstress and stay-at-home wife. Because the living space in the town was too small to accommodate the whole family and the living expenses were much higher in town, the parents sent two girls to live

⁹ Jie-jie: 姐姐, elder sister.

¹⁰ Da-bo: 大伯, big uncle, specifically the eldest brother of father.

¹¹ Di-di: 弟弟, little brother

in the countryside with relatives. Her knowledge about the difference between handwritten and printed 4 came from the checks her father got—the stamped 4 and written 4 were different.

She had a formal name, Wang Pan-di, given by her parents, but in the countryside, people addressed her as Xian-me¹² because she came from the town.

“What do they call your sister then? Xian-jie¹³?”

“Close. She is Xian-ren¹⁴.”

“My name is so similar to yours.” Huai-jin felt she found a connection with this new friend and got excited: “my nick-name is Lan-zi; they said it was because I was sent to my family with a basket. But I have a formal name, A-Xie.”

The knowledgeable Pan-di shook her head: “A-Xie is not a formal name. Xie is your last name, so this is only another nickname based on your last name.”

Huai-jin was baffled. She tried to search through her memory but then realized that she had no other names.

After she went back home, she asked her parents about her formal name, but they could give no clear answer. The two adults looked at each other, opening and closing their mouths, not sure how to face the little girl, who glowed with longing. Their explanation was that she was a girl and sent away by her biological father rather early, so she might not have had a name then; but her dad was a landlord anyway, so he might have given her one but didn't tell them, maybe because he thought it was unnecessary information; or maybe he did mention her name when he sent her here, but the couple were illiterate, so they paid no attention and couldn't remember.

Not having a formal name deeply disturbed Huai-jin. She asked her adopted parents whether they could give her a formal name, but they declined right away, waving their hands: “We have no knowledge. We know no characters. We ourselves have no serious name, neither did your brothers. You already knew much more than us, and you will know even more; you could name yourself after you know more characters.”

Huai-jin felt lost. The deep fissure she felt years later between “literacy” and “illiteracy” began then, and she couldn't tell where she belonged. When she recalled the interaction with her parents, she realized that their response was no more than a refusal, and they had no expectation

¹² Xian-me: 县(town)妹(little sister)

¹³ Xian-jie: 县(town)姐(elder sister)

¹⁴ Xian-ren: 县(town)人(person)

that she would name herself with enough literacy one day. For a long while she didn't know which side she belonged to. She was drawn to the “literacy” side, surely; but she felt she couldn't get rid of the “illiteracy” side despite her inner resistance to it.

After her parents' refusal, Huai-jin went up to Pan-di. She idolized this new knowledgeable friend of hers: not only because of the vibrantly red ribbon dancing on her hair or her seldomly-patched dresses, but also because of a kind of demeanor, one which girls from the country lack, and which Huai-jin longed for. Once in a while, Pan-di went into the city and lived there for some time. So despite their similar age, Pan-di appeared like a big sister, knowing just a bit more than everyone else.

Pan-di laughed out loud: “We are from the same generation! How dare I give you a name? I only know many easy characters—you basically learned them in class too!”

“But my parents know even fewer characters than me,” said Huai-jin, frustratedly, “my dad might know some, but I haven't seen him. He doesn't even want me. Could I not have a name for my whole life then? It wouldn't come down to me naming myself, right?”

Pan-di smiled, “You could, when you learn more characters!”

“I envy you. You already have a name.”

“Come on, what's there to envy?” Pan-di pouted. But she soon figured that Huai-jin, with her limited knowledge, couldn't empathize with her. She then explained patiently, “My older sister was named Zhao-di¹⁵. I was named Pan-di. My parents weren't happy that we are girls. They just wanted a son. There wasn't enough space in the town, so they didn't even want us there any more.”

“You are just as pitiful as me. My biological dad didn't want me either.” Huai-jin sympathized.

Maybe it was later in the same day, or maybe it was the second day—Huai-jin couldn't remember correctly—during the class break, an idea flashed through her mind. She ran to grab

¹⁵ Zhao-di: 招 (recruit, conjure) 弟 (little brother), another name people give to daughters in order to get a son.

Pan-di, who was about to walk out of the door: “What do you think about me asking Chen *Lao-shi* for a name?”

“That is a good idea!” Huai-jin paused to think for a moment and analyzed: “You are very smart, and she likes you; she must be willing to think of a name for you. And she will definitely give you a good name since she knows so many characters!”

Huai-jin asked her new friend to accompany her, and Pan-di said yes without hesitation. When the class finished, Huai-jin and her friend caught Chen *Lao-shi* before she left the podium.

“Chen *Lao-shi*, can you come up with names?”

“Pardon?”

“Can you give us formal names? I don't have one; she has one, but it isn't good. Can you give us some good names?”

Chen *Lao-shi* smiled. Dimples appeared on her usually stern face, and her eyes curved into crescent moons. As two girls had guessed, Chen *Lao-shi* was not only willing but also glad that Huai-jin had asked for names for her friend and herself.

“Good girl,” Chen *Lao-shi* caressed her hair. “Our newborn nation needs progressive, smart, and diligent kids like you. You are the future of our homeland.” And that day, the two girls got their own names: one is Huai-jin, and the other is Wo-yu, combining into the idiom *Huai jin wo yu*, which originates from Qu Yuan's *Chu-Ci*¹⁶. The idiom's literal meaning is “embracing jades”; the names hinted at keeping high virtues and capability.

So, at ten years old, Huai-jin finally got a real name, a name she used for her whole life.

On that day, when she was about to part from Wo-yu—formerly Pan-di—and return home with her siblings, Wo-yu said to her: “I didn't expect that you would help ask a name for me.”

Huai-jin was stunned for seconds. As young as she was, she couldn't clearly discern Wo-yu's attitude and she wasn't sure if she should apologize to her for her unauthorized action. But the next second, Wo-yu smiled: “Thank you so much. I really love this name. I think, I think... after today, we may become best friends.”

¹⁶ Monumental Chinese long poem written before 2c. BC. Its author Qu yuan is the origin of the Dragon Boat festival.

A quiet and reserved girl, Wo-yu didn't smile often, but her smiles were beautiful. Huai-jin remembered that whenever she smiled, her gleaming eyes seemed to hold all the radiances of the day time.

After a few months, the group of students got smaller.

Not every kid found learning interesting. For many of them, the characters were signs tricking them around, and math was some magic they could never understand. As the content became more complex, what they learned diverged further from what they were familiar with in life. Besides, as they still needed to help out at home, going to school meant a reduction in their playing time.

Huai-jin's siblings were among them. Her brother started to skip school and play at the river. In the beginning, he carefully asked the sisters to help keep this secret from their parents, but later, he soon realized that he wasn't the only one. After he discerned his parents' easy-going attitude, he played hooky much more blatantly.

A-Zhang soon followed him. When Huai-jin saw their free textbooks again, A-Zhang had already turned them into insoles in their straw shoes. At the time, there were only two pairs of cloth shoes at home, shared by the whole family and reserved for long trips. The straw shoes pinched their feet a lot when they walked, but they were more comfortable after being padded with paper. When the neighboring adults saw the paper-padded shoes, they praised A-Zhang for her domestic intelligence and thriftiness. Huai-jin appreciated her sister's effort to make her shoes more comfortable, but each time she removed her left shoe and saw the crumpled pages of "Introduction to Addition" inside, a wave of inexplicable sadness washed over her.

Continuing to stay in school made Huai-jin an outlier. Indeed, in the past, she had had problems "blending in" with the groups of village girls. She also had limited interest in the popular games among girls like "grass-stem fight," preferring to shrimp in the water with the boys. Yet as she grew up, the boys became unwilling to include a girl in their group, while she also lost interest in romping. For now, going to school became the best part of her life.

Admittedly, when she commuted between school and home and passed the river and where she saw the boys tangling with each other or rolled on the grass, she felt some loneliness. Yet when she arrived at school, put down her small patched bag by the seat of Wo-yu in the first row and placed her textbook on the table, she felt she returned to her world and all the negative emotions cleared.

She sensed that one major reason she felt no loneliness in the school was Wo-yu. The longer they were friends, the more inseparable they became. Though Wo-yu never spoke explicitly about her sorrow, Huai-jin knew that she was also lonely. This poor girl, though in better clothes, had also been an abandoned child. Her parents left her sister and her with a relative, and as her sister had been married recently, she was left all alone. And this reserved girl, though always able to decently join others' conversations, hardly expressed her own feelings. However, now, these two lonely girls, excluded by the rest of the world, came together, remarking the world and feeling lonely no more, just like two fragmented semi-circles were put together and suddenly became a whole.

Huai-jin knew they were so different; they had different family backgrounds and personalities. But when she looked into the dark calm of Wo-yu's eyes, the lights inside were deep but clear like wells, in which she could see herself: her real self.

School made Huai-jin realize one more thing:

She was smart.

After finishing grade one, she and Wo-yu were recommended to skip a grade into grade three, while other classmates routinely rose to grade two. And she found that even when most people studied for more time than her, she could still perform better than them. She realized that she was even smarter than Wo-yu, not just because Wo-yu said so: with her knowledge and background from the town, even in math—her favorite and most skilled subject—she still learned things a bit slower than Huai-jin.

In the third-grade classroom, there were only a handful of students from all nearby villages, and the number of girls could be counted with one hand. In these circumstances, the

smart and diligent Huai-jin and Wo-yu even became a bit famous, as the nearby officers often used them as an example to demonstrate to the villagers the propaganda of New China: “Women can hold up half of the sky,” and “Giving birth to a boy or a girl has no difference.” One time, an officer from the town who came to inspect and visit dropped by the school and tested Huai-jin and Wo-yu on their sentence construction and math calculations. He was obviously delighted with the result, as he cried out “Excellent!” three times. Not only did he praise Chen *Lao-shi* and two girls in front of the whole school, encouraging them to continue working hard and contribute to the construction and revival of the nation, but he also left them each a little notebook.

It was a small notebook, only half as big as the textbook. It was made with cheap kraft paper with Chairman Mao's portrait printed on the top. Huai-jin remembered it was right around potato sowing time. When Huai-jin returned home happily with her award, the family was swamped with labor. As soon as her eldest brother saw her, he called her for help. Later in the day, the men were enjoying the cool breeze around their door, but her mother called her and A-Zhang to help with the cooking. When she lit the firewood, the smoke blew into her face, burning up the sweat hanging around her temple. That sticky feeling extinguished half of her excitement.

Still, When the family sat around the dinner table in the evening, she brought up her good performance in the daytime. The parents didn't look interested until she mentioned the notebook given by the town officer. After hearing about something substantial, the father eventually had some reaction: “Great, Lan-zi, great.” He seemed to be happy too, but Huai-jin was old enough to feel the difference: the way that her father was happy was different from the way that Chen *Lao-shi* and Wo-yu were happy. His happiness was just as true and sincere, but it was a shallow well, not diving into the bottom of his heart.

In the winter that year, before students all went back for spring festival¹⁷ break, Chen *Lao-shi* organized a small activity. Everyone would bring something from home to put in a red pocket and take away a red pocket made by someone else. Chen *Lao-shi* also participated; she put in a few pencils and an eraser.

Huai-jin searched around her house and could barely find anything to put in the pocket. Wo-yu, as Huai-jin knew, put in a pair of gloves she sewed herself; but Huai-jin owned almost

¹⁷ = Chinese new year

nothing. She knew a bit of straw-weaving, but those products were usually too big for a pocket and too rough as a gift. She eventually put in several pieces of dried sweet potato, which was the only thing she could afford to give out.

She never knew who picked up her red pocket, but she always remembered that she picked up the red pocket made by Chen *Lao-shi*.

The feeling of the moment when she opened the red pocket and saw what was inside was an intense color that could never fade away in her memory. Those were the first pencils she owned in her whole life. Now, along with the notebook she received as an award, she could eventually write on paper. She carefully tied a thread to her eraser and fixed it to the end of her first pencil and then moved it to the next pencil when the first one was used up. All four pencils were used till they were only as long as a thumb nail: Huai-jin made them last that long by fixing the pencil head to a wooden stick.

During the summer vacation, Wo-yu was to go to town and visit her parents and brothers. It was a day trip, so she invited Huai-jin to go with her. That was the first time in Huai-jin's memory of going into town. Her foster parents told her that she had been carried there when she was little, but Huai-jin was too small to remember it.

The town's buildings stood modestly taller than those in the countryside, a humble assertion of modernity and civilization with their three to five stories nudging against the sky. Huai-jin's gaze swept through the town's heart where the police station stood sentry with guards in the front, shops teemed with the day's commerce, and the hospital gleamed with a large bright red cross affixed to it. But it was the middle school that captured her focus, right away spurring her deepest yearnings. This was no mere extension of a village square; here stood a gateway framed with a nameplate, heralding a realm of education beyond the humble rural classrooms she knew: a single house with its patch of earth. Through the iron gate's resolve, Huai-jin glimpsed the solemn edifices within, their stature promising a world of knowledge as yet untapped by her and her village peers. In this quiet observation, she heard the whisper of her potential future.

Seeing that her friend was astonished and impressed, Wo-yu giggled: “that was where you will go to school in the future.”

Wo-yu brought Huai-jin to her parents' apartment, on the first floor of a three-story building. Huai-jin was first surprised that a family would need to share a building with others, but soon she realized that though having a smaller space, the apartment's conditions were far better. The front door was decorated with the red couplets and *Fu* paper square¹⁸ left from the Spring Festival; the bags of trash were placed in orderly fashion by the door, waiting for the janitors to pick them up. Unlike the concrete floor in Huai-jin's place, the apartment was covered with white ceramic tiles. When Huai-jin looked down, she could see a vague reflection of herself on the floor. There was a lightbulb. Most astonishingly, Huai-jin saw a sewing machine placed by the wall. Though Huai-jin knew that Wo-yu's mother did some tailoring work, the presence of a sewing machine was still beyond her imagination. She tried her best not to look around, behaving like a decent guest.

It was a weekday daytime, so Wo-yu's father was away working in the factory, but her mother was at home with her two brothers. Wo-yu seemed happy to see her mother, but their interaction was, in Huai-jin's perception, much less close than what mother and daughter should be. Huai-jin thought— although her own parents didn't care or understand about her schooling, they did know things about her—but Wo-yu's mother did not even know much about how everything was going on back in the village. When Wo-yu asked about her siblings, her mother gave her stunning news: her biggest sister was pregnant “again”.

“What do you mean by 'again'? I didn't remember she gave birth to any child before.” Wo-yu was confused.

“She didn't know she was pregnant the first time, so she miscarried when her husband beat her,” Wo-yu's mother said casually as she folded clothes. “Pan-di—and you too, *Xie yatou*¹⁹—should be more aware of your body's situation when you are married, so your husband can be more cautious when you're pregnant. Some rural men still beat their wives knowing they're pregnant, but we town people usually don't do that. Children are important; miscarriage is really a loss.”

¹⁸ Red couplets: common way to celebrate Chinese spring festival. Composed of a pair of blessing-related poetry lines vertically pasted on both sides of the door and a four-character horizontal scroll above the door. *Fu*: 福, luck/blessing, Chinese also paste a paper square of paper *fu* on the door.

¹⁹ *Yatou*: 丫头, little girl

The air suddenly became somber. Huai-jin could not utter a word—she shouldn't say much as a visitor anyway. She was mature enough to stay properly silent. Her foster father didn't beat family members, but she knew it was not uncommon in the village.

Later, Wo-yu's mother asked Wo-yu to stay for a meal with her brothers and invited Huai-jin to join too. At the lunch table, Wo-yu's mother directed the conversation toward Huai-jin's life. *How old are you? How many brothers do you have? Can you sew? What can you cook? What do you like to do in your free time?* Wo-yu introduced Huai-jin to her, but it seemed that she couldn't be bothered to remember Huai-jin's name; she kept calling her Xie Ya-tou²⁰.

Huai-jin thought the lunch was very good, as she usually ate sweet potatoes at home. She didn't pay much attention to the conversation. Many years later, when she recalled the details of that day, she realized the meaning behind Wo-yu's mother's zealous gaze—it was an examination for a potential candidate for a daughter-in-law.

Traveling by foot between the village and town took around two to three hours. When they went back to the rural area, it was already the dinner hour. With each side's guardians' permission, Huai-jin stayed over in Wo-yu's place. Wo-yu used to share the room with her sister, but after her sister and a cousin got married and moved to their husband's place, Wo-yu temporarily had her own room.

After the sky darkened, one could barely find a light in the village. The southern village, close to the Tropic of Cancer, had relatively stable and almost-equal day and night time. Oil lamps or candles were luxuries in the village. With the scarce existence of artificial light, people rose and worked with the sunrise and they rested and slept after sunset.

In the darkness, the person by one's side seemed to become much more intimate. Despite the summer heat, Huai-jin tried to stay close to Wo-yu, feeling the heat and softness of her body, which, at this moment, felt like an anchor to the world for her. After coming back from the town, many unfamiliar feelings overwhelmed her. Lost and confused, she had to grasp the girl by her side to confirm reality. As the night deepened, the girls still could not fall asleep, whispering to

²⁰ Ya-tou: 丫头, What elders call a little girl

each other in very low voices as the house was so small and the walls were barely soundproof. Wo-yu suggested going to the back of her house to watch the stars.

Summer night in a southern village is quiet with sounds. The sounds of cicadas, frogs, and sometimes livestock, weave together, lingering through every corner of the village. The air was thick, sweet, and warm with moisture, sometimes disturbed by wind, which brought not only coolness but also the light rustling as it blew through the leaves. The two girls found a somewhat clean spot under trees where there was no livestock waste. They sat down side by side and leaned on the trunks of trees. Now they could let their voices out a bit more.

“What do you want to do in the future?” asked Wo-yu.

“I don't know... I was thinking about it.” Huai-jin murmured. She ended up circumventing the question, “Not sure what my parents would plan for me.”

Wo-yu turned her head and looked at Huai-jin: “I am not talking about your parents. Not what your parents want. It's what YOU want.”

She was serious. Without turning her own head, Huai-jin couldn't see Wo-yu's face. But from the stars in the firmament, she seemed to see Wo-yu's eyes. She knew that she was serious.

So Huai-jin had to take it seriously too. “I want...” Huai-jin repeated. Could she really want something? Did she deserve to have her own desire? In the village, everyone just shared a simple desire, that they, and their family, could live without starving. The men might desire to get a wife and have kids; because of the unbalanced gender ratio, not everyone could get married. A woman—what about a woman? They would get married and have kids and hoped that they could bear more sons and that their sons could get married and their daughters-in-law could bore sons. Huai-jin didn't think she was old enough to desire.

She said: “I want... not to be like your sister.”

Realizing that she might be misunderstood, she explained: “I mean, I don't want to be trapped like her. I don't want my life to just be about marrying someone.”

“I know, I know.” Wo-yu understood even before her explanation. “My sister, she is such a good person. You know, she took care of me well when I was little and was like my second mother... even more than my mother. But now she is married, even though she does everything else so well, everyone just picks on her because she didn't give birth to a son. But my

brother-in-law—you heard my mom today—he made her miscarry, but people don't even reproach him. They pitied him for losing a kid.”

“It is scary.” Huai-jin murmured. “But they would just say, every girl is like that.”

Wo-yu was in silence.

Among all the chaos, Huai-jin seemed to catch something in her head—something important, something that made her special, something that set her apart from the traditional girls. She started to speak again, hesitantly: “Can we be different? Wo-yu, can we be different?”

“Why not?” Said Wo-yu. “You are in school. Because I am in school, my parents already treat me a bit differently from my sister. Huai-jin, you are smart. You can continue on this road.”

“Can I?” Huai-jin was lost in intertwining thoughts. “I am a village girl.”

“Of course you can. You can go to... middle school... university! Chen Lao-shi said you have that potential.” Wo-yu affirmed to her “Huai-jin, you could go further than me.”

“I don't want to go further than you. I want to stay with you forever.”

“Yes, yes, I will stay with you forever.”

“I know now—what I want. We will be decent people like Chen *Lao-shi*. We are literate now, right? I hope we can do the kind of work that literate people do. I want to be around people who can read and write. And among them, you. We may have different occasions, but we can be neighbors. We can visit each other often and exchange our experiences in our life, so we can both share two sets of experiences.”

“I hope so too.”

“Wo-yu, why are we two girls? Why aren't we a boy and a girl? Then we could get married and form a family and nothing can separate us.”

Wo-yu didn't say anything right away. Eventually, she responded; her voice was soft and light, as if coming from a star from the sky: “That indeed sounds good to me. Maybe next incarnation.”

Huai-jin stared at the sky as she shared everything with Wo-yu. Wo-yu let down her guard and opened her heart, sharing a lot of thoughts that she usually kept to herself. The

firmament was dark and deep like a curtain, with the stars scattering on it like diamonds; they all seemed very, very distant from her and Wo-yu sitting on the earth. Many years later, Huai-jin could still remember the stars floating and blinking that night, stars which she could hardly see again after her daughter moved her to the city.

She wasn't entirely naive to the destinies that awaited girls in her position, but she had always skirted around the reality. However, from a certain moment—perhaps it was that night when she began to ponder her future—it struck her that there was no escaping it. Staying in the village meant she would likely be married by sixteen. And who would her partner be if she remained there? As she thought through every boy in the village around her age, she realized that she could not imagine a contented life with any of them. Some of the good boys left the village for a better life, and they would likely marry a girl elsewhere. Some stuck to their land and were probably good-enough husbands in many village girls' lives, but could she, knowing so many characters and so much math, really communicate with such a husband? There was also a boy or two whose whole family sacrificed themselves to support his study. Their sisters were badly married for high *Cai-li*²¹ or good connections. She knew if she married into a family like this, she would be no different from those sisters, also becoming a part of the support and fertilizer for her husband. She would have to step back to the beginning of her journey and stay there forever; everything she learned would no longer belong to her.

She could not live a content life if she stayed here.

But on the other side—the side that she was marching to right now—everything was unfamiliar. She wasn't born there and wasn't raised to live there. That world had only revealed itself a little bit to her, but she could already tell that while there was something attracting her, there were also things that she didn't want to blend in with—such as the calculation she felt in Wo-yu's mother's attitude. To get there, she had to change; but to change, she had to lose. She already felt her presence disjointed her from the past—her innocent and wild past in the village—which other village kids still owned but she had lost.

But she was lucky—she thought. At least she had Wo-yu, who would travel the distance with her—they would be together. In such a night, they redefined each other; stemming from the past, the girl by her side became an integrated part of her future. Their lives from now on would

²¹ Cai-li: 彩礼, A dowry that the (family of a) man gives to the family of a woman in order to marry her.

intertwine. They would witness each other's change and be the guardians of each others' old age. And no matter how strange the world they were stepping into, with each other, they would never be lonely.

Huai-jin and Wo-yu skipped a grade again after they finished the third grade.

Wo-yu hesitated about skipping another grade. She felt the pace of schooling was just right for her. She could see herself going either way, and she usually preferred the more comfortable way—or the way that took the least extra action. Huai-jin pushed her, begged her, and persuaded her with all the reasons she could think of.

Huai-jin ingeniously thought skipping grades would be the optimal solution for both of them, as they were growing up every day and approaching the age of marriage. Wo-yu's big sister carried her first child at the age of nineteen, and Huai-jin's parents were talking about a marriage between A-Zhang and their second son. Huai-jin was now twelve; Wo-yu was one year older than Huai-jin, already thirteen. Although there weren't any signs about their potential marriages, they could still feel a judgment day coming closer and closer.

“The longer we stay in the elementary school, the longer we can enjoy the free education.” Wo-yu timidly objected. Her voice became even lower when Huai-jin looked into her eyes.

“Come on, Wo-yu, we know math. This just means we learn the same amount of knowledge and get the same degree in less time. I know it may be hard for you, but... We have to try our best to race with time.” Huai-jin stressed. She knew Wo-yu must agree with her. Wo-yu knew everything; she was just evasive and needed help to take action.

“And we can stay in the same class,” said Huai-jin, “we can have each other no matter how hard it is.”

Maybe Wo-yu eventually bought what she said, or maybe she was moved by her sincerity—Wo-yu never told her why—Wo-yu eventually requested to skip grade 4 too.

The independent and loving Chen *Lao-shi* could not help appreciating their strong spirit and work ethic and would not turn down such requests. As a predecessor to the young girls,

Chen *Lao-shi* sometimes talked to them outside of class about being a woman. She told them that the generational sexism was ignorant; women had just as much potential as men. She shared with them legends of historical female figures and recent female martyrs, and she sometimes talked about the friends and junior women she knew who changed their life through hard work. Huai-jin knew that Chen *Lao-shi* must be secretly afraid that they would drop out of school like their past girl classmates, and that she was encouraging them this way since she couldn't really directly make life decisions for them.

Huai-jin told her family about her decision to skip grades, and their reaction was the same—"Great." Their simple comment restrained Huai-jin from saying anything more. For several nights, she suffered from insomnia and kept turning back and forth with her restless thoughts. The fact that could not disclose her thoughts to her family made her even more anxious.

What if she told them more—What would their attitude be? Even A-Zhang was very satisfied with her life as a *tong yang xi*; and she, raised as a daughter, seemed to have even more privileges. Now that she had a wish for herself, everything felt clear for her, in a way that it never was before. She knew that her family was nice and would not do bad things to her, but when she thought about the exact question of whether they would support her to get higher and higher education, she felt powerless. They probably wouldn't. They probably couldn't. They let her study—but that was because it was free. But if she wanted to continue, it would no longer be free.

As they rose to grade 6, their future after elementary school became more and more pressing, and Huai-jin could evade no more. She and Wo-yu found Chen *Lao-shi* to ask the question that had obsessed them for a long time.

In the shabby classroom where daylight poorly lit through, Chen *Lao-shi* gazed gently into the children's eyes, her own filled with an indescribable sorrow that words could not convey. She said slowly and softly, that the tuition plus room and board for middle school was 30 yuan per semester.

30 yuan! Stunned, Huai-jin froze, unaware of her open mouth; even Wo-yu pursed her lips and looked away. Villagers mostly relied on themselves and didn't use money much, but it didn't mean Huai-jin didn't have a sense of its weight. She knew that her family's usual savings might not even make a tenth of it, if they had any savings at all. And recently, the family just found a wife for their first son and exhausted all the money to pay for the his *cai-li*²². They were now getting ready for two sons' weddings, and Huai-jin could see that all the money the family recently saved would go there.

When she felt that reality was so harsh that she could not breathe, Chen *Lao-shi* gently patted her shoulders. No need to worry—she said—they give scholarships to good students.

“Good students?” Huai-jin asked tentatively.

“Yes, good students like you,” Chen Lao-shi confirmed. “You always have the best score in the school, so you are distinctive in your study. You also help other students well with their confusion—I know they all like to ask you for help when I'm not there. So you are virtuous with camaraderie, and you need financial aid. Our organization²³ would definitely grant a student like you the highest level of scholarship.

“And you, Wo-yu, your family has a better financial situation, so you are likely to get the third level of scholarship, and if you helped your classmates and underclassmen more, maybe you can also get the highest level too. Our party is an organization for the common people, so we are a meritocracy. We give opportunities to students with virtues and talents, not the ones with money. Now, we are living in New China. You girls live in a new era. If you work hard enough, your labor will earn what you deserve.”

Huai-jin didn't tell her parents about the scholarship. She knew that her parents might not be able to understand what it would mean to her. Also, as she was still not sure how it would work out. It was even hard for her to believe that people would give money to poor people like her without asking for rewards.

²² Cai-li: 彩礼, dowry given by groom's family to bride's family

²³ refers to CCCP

She didn't want to give her parents any expectations. Her mother was famous for her “big mouth,” passing different messages all around. If you told her a secret today, tomorrow it would no longer be news for half of the village. What if her mother bragged about her, and then it turned out that something happened and she couldn't get the scholarship and go to middle school after all? She could not imagine how much deadly embarrassment she would suffer then.

She didn't want to get her own hopes up either. Every day she secretly prayed to all the supernatural powers she knew of, wishing that everything could turn out the best way. But she was psychologically prepared for the worst. It was like a gamble, and gambling for something did not belong to a village girl like her. What if she couldn't do it? It's much more cruel to lose what you think you have than never to have it in the first place.

And what worried her did happen.

One day Chen *Lao-shi* asked her to stay after school, alone, without Wo-yu. When she looked at Chen *Lao-shi*'s face, she felt she could read much more information than before: tiredness, resignation... she felt there had been a stone hanging in her heart for a long time; at this moment, it eventually fell to the ground.

“I am sorry, Huai-jin,” sighed Chen *Lao-shi*, as she stood face-to-face with Huai-jin alone. “I didn't anticipate they would be so strict about your political background.”

How did she feel then? Huai-jin forgot to be sad, forgot to be down, forgot to remember. She forgot to rebel, while she also forgot to feel resigned. Her body petrified, merely existing there. She knew Wo-yu got the second-level scholarship because for a few days she could feel that Wo-yu was somewhat avoiding her and afraid to talk to her, and as a friend of hers for such a long time, she understood that it was the unexplainable guilt that fortunate ones often have for unfortunate others. Though she was reluctant to acknowledge it, Huai-jin found herself in a plight so unfortunate that it drew pity from everyone around her.

A few days later, Chen *Lao-shi* asked Huai-jin to stay after class again. She grabbed Huai-jin's hand, nervously, with a glimpse of hope: “You are adopted, right? What is the *Cheng-fen*²⁴ of your birth family?”

²⁴ Cheng-fen: literally means “constituent”, referring to the category of family background. In the pre-economic-reform era, this category was somewhat deterministic of citizens' civil rights. Today, North Korea still abides by a similar system.

At the moment, Huai-jin felt an endless bitterness, on her tongue, in her throat, in her heart. She answered with a hoarse voice: “*Lao-shi*, my birth family is even worse. It's landlord.”

She didn't dare to look at Chen *Lao-shi's* eyes, but Huai-jin could feel from the warmth of her hand that the dim light in her teacher's eyes faded and died. Her heart, after the constant numbness for days, throbbed again. She knew she might be Chen *Lao-shi's* favorite student, and there was an unspeakable bond between them. She was proud of that, as she could always make her proud of her, but at this moment, she felt sorry and unworthy. Born a village girl and knowing that it would be her gamble, she was perfectly fine that she had lost. But why must her dear teacher, such an elegant woman, who should enjoy a serene and happy life, suffer along with her? Many years later, after she herself became another Chen *Lao-shi*, she could feel that throb and ache even more intimately. For the majority of her life, she was questioning her own agency in the world. Sometimes she felt she had some power to change something, while sometimes she felt she had nothing at all. Many years later, she realized that she was but a sailor, trying to steer a small boat in the current of history.

For the rest of the 6th grade, she realized that she didn't want to leave her elementary school. She felt maybe Wo-yu was right—maybe they shouldn't skip grades so they could enjoy the guaranteed education longer. In her free time, she sometimes turned the pages back and forth and back and forth, and everything in the book became as familiar to her as her double. She didn't consciously count down, but she could feel from the rising temperature and flourishing trees, that a phase of her life was ending, which to her then meant that a part of her was leaving, and she was trying futilely to catch the tail of it.

On their way walking back home, Wo-yu comforted her: “Huai-jin, don't be sad. I think there is still hope. Maybe there will be extra funds, so they can include more people.”

But Wo-yu knew that comfort like this could deceive no one, as she herself did not believe in it. Huai-jin did not get the scholarship not because she was a bad student but because her *cheng fen* eliminated her from the competition. Indeed, Huai-jin knew Wo-yu knew that too. But she knew she wasn't able to ask for more. She had an even greater fear, that after they went

on different paths their bond would fade and disappear, and that they, so close at the present, would one day have nothing more to share except memory. Then, where would she belong? What new friend could she find?

She asked Wo-yu: "Are you going to middle school?"

She stopped walking and looked at Wo-yu. The bushes rustled in the wind like a prelude to something. Huai-jin was not sure what she hoped to hear.

Wo-yu slowly nodded, "Chen *Lao-shi* talked to my parents."

Both of them were silent. Huai-jin looked into Wo-yu's dark shimmering eyes, and she paused. She didn't know what to say.

One voice inside Huai-jin cried out in a hysterical way: don't let her go. You will lose her if she goes. You will be different. Beg her to stay. Drag her down to stay with you –

Another voice was twisting her heart: Why? Why is it so easy for her? I wanted it more. I planned more. I worked harder.

She felt her throat vibrate, and her voice came out of her mouth:

"Study hard when you go to middle school. Study hard."

Silence.

Huai-jin held Wo-yu's hand and repeated: "Study hard for me."

Wo-yu grabbed her hand tight and said, "I will."

Wo-yu said they would always be good friends. If Huai-jin could not go to middle school with her, they could still get together often, and she could teach her whatever she learnt at school.

"You are so clever—" she remembered what Wo-yu said—"you must be able to catch up with everything even if you are not in a classroom."

But Huai-jin was too mature to hide in her own fantasy like a little girl. Despite her love for knowledge, if she could not continue on with her education, what could it do for her? It would not be a foundation but a burden. What mattered to her, then, would be what mattered now to her mother—the sweet potatoes in the earth, the arrangement of a tiny household, or the birth of sons and grandsons. It would be a different world.

At sunset, the two girls would sometimes lie down together on the grass by the river. Sometimes they just stayed in silence. For Huai-jin, even though they didn't speak a word, she

felt no strangeness, no embarrassment, no boredom. And she always remembered how Wo-yu broke the silence one day –

“Huai-jin,” she said, “how I wish I could give my scholarship to you. I know my family could somehow afford the tuition. You need that money much more than I do.”

It was Wo-yu who said this. The reserved and timid Wo-yu, who hardly expressed her feelings, who hardly imagined anything.

Huai-jin responded: “Thank you, but that is not true. You need that money too.”

She didn't need to explain because they both knew what it meant. Wo-yu's family had money, but they were unwilling to invest in a daughter. Wo-yu's scholarship proved her worth while alleviating the financial burden on her parents, otherwise she would have had a hard time getting her parents' acquiescence to her next stage of schooling, even with Chen *Lao-shi's* persuasion.. Huai-jin loved this feeling that she could tell what Wo-yu meant from a phrase or two even if she didn't say everything. Who could ever be as in tune with her as Wo-yu was, if she lost her one day?

“Wo-yu,” Huai-jin picked up what Wo-yu said, with her eyes closed. “I wish I had money. I wish I could pay not only for my tuition, but also yours. I wish one day I could have enough money to get out of this village—and the town— with you, go somewhere further than our parents and grandparents have ever been to. The text-book says that there is sea, grassland, and desert, right? I wish I could just pay your tuition, for your middle school, your high school, even for Beijing University. I wish that whenever you are in need, I could really help you. Wo-yu, I really wish.”

“I wish that too.”

Huai-jin remembered that the two boys in her adopted family shared one wedding, which took place shortly after Spring Festival, so the family could combine the materials for weddings and new year celebration and save some money. She especially remembered that Mother made the decision to keep the red couplets of Spring Festival for the wedding. The red couplets surely should have had different content for different contexts; but in the village, people didn't know

what the couplets were saying anyway. As long as it was red paper and big black calligraphy, the couplets would satisfy their need for festiveness.

A few days before the wedding, women in Lin started to get ready for the wedding dinner. On several mornings, two girls, along with their mother, need to leave the house early and walk a great distance to find the butchers in nearby villages, carefully selecting ingredients by comparing goods at different places. On the wedding day, Mother, A-Zhang, and Huai-jin all rose up before the day was clear, busy preparing food around the stove. At noon, the men in the family left the house to go to *Da-ge*²⁵'s wife's family's house for the bride's side banquet. However, women—including the bride-to-be A-Zhang—still needed to get ready for the groom's side dinner. They hastily had their lunch around the stove.

In the afternoon, the neighbor woman and A-Zhang's best girl friends came to dress the bride. A-Zhang, in a patchless red dress borrowed from a friend and a pair of clean black cloth shoes, sat on a stool waiting for others to doll her up. Because of the wedding dinner, Lins cooked some rice—a rare food in the household—so A-Zhang could use its washing water to wash her face. The neighbor woman made A-Zhang's hair into a bun on the top of her head, hiding her split hair ends inside. Her bun was tied with red ribbon, with a big red paper flower pinned on one side. Besides a small piece of charcoal that painted her eyebrow, A-Zhang could afford no cosmetics. However, Huai-jin was still impressed by A-Zhang's beauty today. The A-Zhang she was familiar with was monotone. She was always in patched and faded clothes; her shoes were regularly stained with mud, and her face was almost always layered with some soot. But today, A-Zhang was lively and colorful, with light skin, dark hair, and bright red clothes and decorations. It was the same face, but cleaned and free of cinder and dust; the countenance, despite her shyness, was filled with vibrance. Huai-jin saw a glowing radiance of youth in A-Zhang that she had hardly noticed before.

“*Jie-jie*, you look so pretty today.” Huai-jin couldn't help exclaiming.

The woman and girls around giggled: “Why do you still call her *Jie-jie*? It's time to call her *Sao-sao*!” Amongst the laughter, A-Zhang lowered her head with shyness and slight embarrassment, demure and quiet as before.

²⁵ Da-ge: 大(big)哥(elder brother), Eldest brother

Later in the afternoon, the villagers arrived one after another, bringing tables, chairs, and utensils from the wedding lunch at *Da-ge's* bride's maiden house. *Wo-yu* also came with her relatives, but *Huai-jin* was too busy to greet or chat with her. *Da-ge* and his bride, covered by a red veil, walked close in the escort of big crowds. *Huai-jin* and *A-Zhang's* friends also escorted *A-Zhang* to *Er-ge's* side. The guests started to hand red envelopes to two new couples. With every red envelope they received, the couples bowed deeply to the givers. *Huai-jin's* task was to help keep the red envelopes and remember who gave each red pocket, so later she could sit down and record how much money the couples received from each household.

When two couples made it to the house, the adults had already sat the parents in the middle of the living space. The two pairs walked into the house with their arms linked, kneeling and bowing down to the parents and then each other. Afterwards, each groom unveiled his bride, who at that moment became his wife. As a family member, *Huai-jin* was also there, inside the house, witnessing the wedding ceremony. Her adopted parents grinned from ear to ear, every wrinkle on their face filled with their happiness. The crowd clustered around the front door, exclaiming and praising as they watched. In this festive atmosphere, *Huai-jin* hastily put on a happy face to hide the indifference inside her.

Indeed, *Huai-jin* herself was surprised that she felt this way. Everyone told her that she would identify more with the bride as she grew up, and she had thought she would be more nervous and excited to witness this most significant ceremony in women's life. However, as she stood in the living space of her house, surrounded by the noisy guests and old grey walls decorated with red, when she heard her adopted mother admonishing the daughter-in-laws to take care of the housework and their men well, *Huai-jin* suddenly but clearly realized that she no longer belonged here; a part of her spirit had already flown away.

After the ceremony, the crowds at the front door eventually dispersed. The dinner began. *Huai-jin* eventually felt a bit of relief; she got her food and sat by *Wo-yu*. The two pairs of newly weds started to toast the guests table by table. *Huai-jin* raised her head from time to time, looking at *A-Zhang* crossing the crowd.

Wo-yu caught her distraction: "This is the first time you have been at your family's own wedding dinner, right?"

Huai-jin laughed: "Of course—these are all the people in my family."

Wo-yu gently patted her shoulder, giving her a hug: “When my big sister got married, I was like this too. After the wedding, she would belong to another family.”

“My sister is still in my family.” Huai-jin said. But as she said it, she realized what the unexplainable emotion lingering in her heart was. Yes, A-Zhang would still remain in the same house after the wedding, but her identity would from now on be different. Another stage of her life was beginning—she was now someone's wife; her world would start to rotate around one person, and her honor and disgrace would depend on one other person. The relationship between her and this childhood best buddy, after becoming less close for a while, had a qualitative change now: before A-Zhang was her sister and friend, now she was her *Er-ge's* wife first. They could never return to the past.

She could also foresee that her close childhood girlfriends would leave her one by one in the same way.

Except Wo-yu.

She felt Wo-yu's warmth, as her friend gently held her close. Wo-yu didn't say anything, but Huai-jin felt that she knew her.

The Wedding continued. The villagers chatted loudly, bragging about their relatives, echoing each others' brags, making comments about other villagers. Despite being in a big crowd, Huai-jin felt like she was in a separate world; inside the world, the only other being she could see was Wo-yu.

Huai-jin's elementary school, regardless of her will, ended in June. Graduation was not a big thing for a family. It brought no change except that in the evening, when the remaining four family members of Xie sat around the table, Huai-jin's mother asked her father: “Lan-zi won't go to school anymore. What can she do then?”

“Lan-zi is already good enough and she could do whatever she wants,” her father said. “We could think about who she should marry now. There are several guys who also went to elementary school for a few years; they may make good partners.”

Huai-jin felt her heart beat so quickly that it was almost flying out from her throat. Before she thought about what she should say, she had already cut the conversation: “Mom...”

All of the people at the table looked at her. Her brain was blank for a second, and she gradually found her voice: “The Town's middle school's entrance exam is the day after tomorrow. I want to go.”

Her mother looked at her father, who frowned deeply, the wrinkles on his forehead gathering tightly, silent. Under the sparse natural light filtering through the doorway, Huai-jin felt as if the air had solidified. Uttering what she said consumed all her guts. She lowered her gaze to the boiled sweet potato leaves on the table, not daring to look directly at her parents' face again.

Mother, unable to get a clear reaction from her husband, looked back at Huai-jin and asked: “Middle school? I didn't know that middle school is free too.”

“It is not...”

Huai-jin felt everyone's attention focused on her, and she instinctively wanted to hide her eyes. Maybe she should not be so nervous in front of family members. She swallowed hard to calm herself down and said: “Yes, but I can take the test anyway.”

“Why should you take the test?” her father spoke with doubt. “You can't go to middle school anyway. It's not a thing for us poor people.”

“Yes, yes,” her mother added, “and there's no point in going to a middle school. Look at the Zhang Gou-zi on the east side of our village. His family has money and let him finish middle school. But look, what is the result? He is still idling in the village every day. He is a boy, and he finishes middle school, but he still cannot do anything. You are a girl, even if you could finish the school, what can you do? Look at A-Zhang, isn't she living a good life? You may even marry into a better family than ours.”

Though her mother mentioned A-Zhang, A-Zhang herself didn't say a word. She was there, sitting aside, eating quietly and demurely, like every other new bride.

Huai-jin had already imagined this scene in her head thousands of times. Everything was going in the direction that she anticipated. She anticipated that her parents would not support her. More or less, they loved her, but they did what they thought would be right for the family, and sometimes, they even decided for her good—what they thought would be good for her. She knew

she could not convince them to let her continue her education, but she might still be able to strive for a little bit...

“I mean... I just want to see the school. I want to see what is inside. I saw the outside with Wo-yu; the buildings were big and more beautiful than our village's elementary school. But we couldn't get in because they had guards. Ordinary people cannot get in. But on testing day, they will let all the test takers in. I can take this opportunity to visit the school. ”

Huai-jin's parents didn't respond right away. They were eating quietly while thinking. Quiet A-Zhang broke the silence first:

“Dad, Mom, why don't we just let her go? People like us have little opportunity to see what the town's middle school is like inside. Since Lan-zi has a chance, why don't we just let her go? What a rare opportunity! After she comes back, we can also let her describe to us what the school was like, and we can pretend we also got to go inside the middle school ”

So her parents became easy-going as always and granted her the permission. But after dinner, A-Zhang secretly dragged her outside. Before she had a chance to say thank you, A-Zhang already started spoking in a very low voice:

“Lan-zi, please understand our dad and our mom. I started studying with you when we were young; I know you are super smart. But you know the situation of our family—we really don't have money.

“Honestly, we are already lucky girls. They are already nice parents. There is nothing more we can hope for.”

Many years later, Huai-jin tried to recall—why did she want to go to take the test, given that her chance of going to middle school was meager? Maybe because she still wanted to prove herself— although maybe it was to nobody—as people either already recognized her or would never bother to care what she proved. She was also gambling one last time; and at the same time, she felt, she was trying to confront her fate, waiting for her fate's answer. Maybe she was trying to refuse to accept reality without knowing whether her act was that of a self-deceiving coward or a courageous rebel.

On the second day, Huai-jin rose early in the morning, as the test was in the morning, and the walk to the town would take her two to three hours. Indeed, she naturally woke up before the rooster started crowing. It was summer, but the sun was still under the horizon. In the darkness she packed and left the house alone. When she left the village, she turned her head back as if someone was calling her from behind, but there was nothing but the vast of fog. She gazed at the mist-wreathing village sleeping in the moonlight for a short while. She felt complex feelings starting to weave together in her heart; before they fermented into anything, she turned back and continued walking forward.

When she passed by her elementary school, where two villages intersect, Wo-yu was already there. The two girls walked together on the muddy path, under the dawning sky. If seen from far away, they were only two small silhouettes, whose contours were lightly gilded by the sunshine. Without much time to rest or ponder, they traveled forward to an unknown episode of life.

The tests were on Chinese and math. It was a little harder than what Huai-jin and Wo-yu usually did, which Huai-jin understood—no matter how well Chen *Lao-shi* taught, their resources were still not comparable to those of the kids in the town.

After the test, Huai-jin tried to move on, acting no differently any other fifteen-year-old village girls around her. Wo-yu, upon her parents' request, went to live in town to take care of her brothers, leaving Huai-jin alone in the village. Feeling too idle at home, she went to work in the construction site ten kilometers away from home. The government was working on building a stone road—substituting the original muddy road—to connect the villages and town. They blasted a mountain as a small quarry. The workers picked up the stones in the quarry and broke them into smaller pieces—smaller than the size of an egg—and submitted to them in exchange for money.

Huai-jin got a hammer and a basket for her job. She walked uphill into the quarry, picked up the small stones she could find and filled the basket. She was short, but picking up the stones

on the ground still required her to bend her waist low. With more and more stones in the basket at her back, she needed to lower her back to walk.

She rose up as before when it was all dark, so she could move in the quarry before the sun began to burn. In the afternoon, she found shade, using a hammer to break the small pieces of stones into even smaller pieces.

Once she accidentally pounded her left hand with the hammer—luckily she wasn't using her full strength—but she still hurt badly. Her left hand was swollen for two days and couldn't exert any force.

She was also getting used to the intensity of labor. As she got more and more familiar with the procedures, she also developed more intuition on the techniques and grew more control over the stones. She gradually knew which stones needed her to hammer with two hands and when she should fix the stone with one hand; at what exact moment should retract her left hand and at what speed her right hand should pound so that she could break the stones successfully without hurting her left hand.

In the dusk, she went to her supervisor, piling her stones on the ground.

At night, she slept on the mountain. The dorm was no more than a woodshed that she and other workers slept under. The spot could neither block the damp wind nor repel the bugs. Other workers started to chat about their family and gossip in their village, but Huai-jin only wanted to close her eyes and rest alone.

Despite the noise from the other people, Huai-jin felt like she was entering her own emotional and spiritual world. In the endless darkness and tiredness, she thought about Wo-yu. Staring at the moon, she wondered what Wo-yu was doing at the moment under the same moon. Sewing with her mother? Cooking for her brother? She felt hard to imagine now, as the quarry was so different from the town. Would she think about her too? Could she imagine her life in the quarry?

Sometimes she wished that Wo-yu was here too. At the moment when she hurt herself with the stone or when she was deadly tired, she became so sensitively aware that she was alone. She would suddenly feel so lonely and vulnerable, strongly desiring that Wo-yu would be here too giving her a hug and comforting her. But the intense work would soon numb her again. Yet at night when she let down her guards to the world, all the vulnerable emotions got back to her. She

would again realize the distance between the quarry and the town and the diverging paths between Wo-yu and her, feeling tears streaming down her face quietly. But after a night's sleep, she would get used to the solitude again.

She gradually found the pace of her new life. In the sweat, tiredness, and soreness, she tried to distract herself from her test and the trivial things in the village. Indeed, she didn't particularly dislike a physically tiring life like this — for this short while. The life she disliked was actually the life in the village, where she had few things to do and nothing could change. At least here, she could work hard and have money in exchange.

Her secluded life was unexpectedly disrupted one day while she was working in the quarry: she received word that two visitors were waiting for her at the mountain's base. She was confused. She thought maybe it was her family, but she could not imagine what situation would make her family have two people come so far to talk to her. When she saw who was coming, she was stunned.

“Wo-yu? Chen *Lao-shi*? Why are you here?”

The teacher, who had traveled many miles for her student, announced the good news: “You are admitted by Town's middle school.”

Wo-yu added: “You are fifth from the top. The top four students were all from the town elementary school.”

The news about her school and her test were like a star from another world. She wasn't surprised that she got in; indeed, any result of the test wouldn't have surprised her. What surprised her was that this news came so close to her and that Chen *Lao-shi* was right there in front of her, reminding her of the world she was ready to give up. And her best friend stood there too, looking at her with pleading eyes, in which every light was saying “don't say give up” to her.

She even felt a bit ridiculous, as they should know what she would have to say.

“Chen *Lao-shi*, you know my situation. My family really doesn't have money. I am working here all day long, but I have only earned two yuan for the last eight days. I don't think I can support myself.”

The fact that Chen *Lao-shi* and Wo-yu came before her family made her realize what must have happened. Her family would have already got her offer, but they had no intention of letting her know. She could imagine them hiding her offer even when she went back and telling her they received nothing, so she could give up her desire to go to middle school naturally and get used to the life she should live.

And she indeed had little grievance against them. They did not have money—this was a solid fact. Letting her know that she could have gotten in if her family had more money might be crueler for her and the family—anyway, she was an adopted daughter.

“Huai-jin, you should know that getting admitted is very hard,” said Chen *Lao-shi*. “Not everyone graduated from elementary school, and among them, not everyone came to take the entrance exam. There were around a thousand applicants, but only 100 got admitted. You should know how precious your spot is. There are so many people in the town who want such a spot but do not have one. You should not waste what you have.”

“But my family...” Huai-jin stuttered. She saw how her foster parents worked diligently to save money for her brothers' marriage, she knew it was not only out of love but also because of their power—they could carry on their blood and name. But she knew that in her parents' views, she would never deserve such investment as a girl—not even if she was their biological daughter.

“I went to your family first, Huai-jin,” Chen *Lao-shi* interrupted her. Before Huai-jin could digest what she said, she continued, “I talked to your parents. You have good parents. Although you are a girl, they want the best for you. I told them what going to middle school could mean for you so they could understand. They now agree that it is a rare chance for you and would not stop you from going.”

“But money...”

“Your brothers—” this time, Wo-yu cut in. “Don't you remember you have two biological brothers in the town? You should go to find your two brothers in the town. They are making money, and they can help you. If you get more education, in the future, you can also help them back.”

That was the first time Huai-jin realized what kind of mutual relationship she might be able to have with her brothers. She knew that girls could rely on brothers; brothers can go to their

sisters' post-marriage household with weapons to protect sisters when their husband or mother-in-law mistreats them. But such an action was either out of the bond of blood and love or the reputation of her maiden family. She didn't realize that she would be able to reward them one day in the future. Is that the power that she—a little girl—could have?—With her own power, rather than the power of her father, husband, or son? Did it mean that she, a girl, right now, was already a worthy investment?

Huai-jin had never tried to contact her brothers before. She did not know where they were, except that they had been sent to the town. She had resisted initiating contact with them because she was scared; it was intimidating to see people, strangers, who she was supposed to be so close with. But she could not think of an alternative solution, and a glimpse of the hope of continuing her education refreshed her resolve, surmounting all the embarrassment and vulnerability. Accompanied by Wo-yu, she went to the village of her birth. By asking around, she figured out the location of her biological father's house.

In front of the house, she remembered that it would be the house where she was born, where she had cried out the first sound in her life, and where she had lost her mother. But ironically, she had no memory of it, and everything around here—every person, every tree, every brick—was unfamiliar to her. She came from here, but she didn't belong here. She had never spent a day playing under the old tree in front of that door, nor did any of the clothes hanging on the clothesline belong to her. She could hear the sounds inside weaving together, sounds that her voice had never been a part of.

She trembled and grabbed Wo-yu's hand. Wo-yu squeezed back and patted her gently with her other hand, pulling her back into the real world from her thoughts. She knocked on the door that looked not much different from Lin's. After a few seconds, a boy opened it. He looked around her age, having some similar traits to Huai-jin's on his face. He seemed to be surprised that two strange girls were knocking on his door.

“Who are you looking for? My mother just went out.”

“I am looking for Mr. Xie Dong.”

“Why are you looking for my father? ... Wait a minute.” He turned around, shouting, “Dad, Dad, two girls are looking for you.”

She listened to his dad calling back. For a moment, she almost forgot that the person he called to was also her dad.

Her dad came. Standing at the door, he looked at two girls. “You are...” His gaze stopped at Huai-jin: “You...”

“Xie *Shu*²⁶, I am your daughter, the one living with the Lins. This is my friend; she is just accompanying me.” Pausing for a second, Huai-jin continued, “I want to find my brothers. I heard they are now in the town, but I don't know where exactly they are and how to find them. Could you please give me their addresses?”

She thought about asking her father for money too, but the moment she saw the little boy, she decided not to. She thought she could overcome everything with her firm resolution, but in that moment, she realized she was at once so proud and so vulnerable.

“Ah... yes, yes, you ... you siblings should connect with each other. So your *Da-ge*²⁷ is now an apprentice in the health clinic. There's only one in the town, so it should be easy to find. Your *Er-ge*²⁸ is working as a barber in a hydropower station— I don't really know where that is... Is everything going well at the Lins'? Ah... Do you want to come in and sit? Your two little brothers and sisters... ah, at least your *San-di*²⁹ and *Xiao-mei* are here today...”

She didn't let him finish: “Thank you very much, Xie *Shu*. But we need to go back before it gets dark. I am very sorry. ”

“Ah, no problem... you can come visit when you have time...”

On the way back, Huai-jin was silent. Wo-yu felt for her. She patted her: “Don't be down. No one can force you to go there again. ”

Huai-jin couldn't help recalling her biological father's facial expression over and over again. His naivete, his embarrassment, his... condescension. She had no malice towards her step-mother or half-siblings, but how could he assume that his children with different

²⁶ *Shu*: 叔, literally refers to father's younger brother, but it is also often used to address men in father's generation, just like “uncle” in English.

²⁷ *Da ge*: 大(big)哥(elder brother), Eldest brother

²⁸ *Er ge*: 二(two; second)哥, Second eldest brother

²⁹ *San di*: 三(third, three)弟(younger brother), Third younger brother

mothers—one growing up somewhere else without any of his care while some grew up under his support—could sit down and become real siblings?

Last time, Huai-jin accompanied Wo-yu to town; this time, Wo-yu went with her. They found their way by asking around. When Huai-jin saw the sign “clinic” from afar, she slowed her pace, and stopped a few steps away from the gate. Spotting Huai-jin's nervousness, Wo-yu patted her shoulder: “It is right there. Aren't you excited to see your brother?”

Yes. No. She was so afraid. The closer to the destination, the more she wanted to run away.

She let out a deep breath: “What if he is not there?”

“I think he will be. But anyway, I am with you. We can always figure something out.”

Huai-jin breathed deeply again. She knew her concern was not the real cause of her anxiety. It was working hours, and his dorm was here too. Even if he wasn't working, they could just ask around. She was afraid of something greater than embarrassment.

“I was too little. I don't think he even knows what I look like.” A jump of topic.

“You must look like him. He will know.”

“I am a sister coming from nowhere. I guess I am no more than a stranger.”

“You are bound by blood.”

Huai-jin recalled her father, who was also bound to her by blood. Meanwhile, Wo-yu took her hand, which was already glossed with sweat. “I'm here, no matter what,” Wo-yu assured her, infusing Huai-jin with strength. Hand in hand, they entered the clinic.

“Hello.” Just as the person at the front desk noticed her, Huai-jin asked the simple question which she had rehearsed a thousand times in her mind. “Is Xie *Tong-zhi*³⁰ here?”

“Which Xie *Tong-zhi*?”

“Xie...” Huai-jin lost her voice. She just realized that she didn't know her *Da-ge*'s name. Pausing for a moment, she calmed down and collected her thoughts: “He is around sixteen. He comes from the village. I think he was sent here two years ago.”

³⁰ Tong-zhi: 同志, comrade

“Ah, so it's Xie Jian-yang. Right? You are looking for him?” The receptionist was a bit surprised. “He is right inside helping out. You can't go inside. Please stay here and wait. You may take a seat there. I will go in and check.”

Huai-jin and Wo-yu sat down, watching the receptionist disappear behind a door. After a while, the door opened. Huai-jin lifted her head and tightened her grasp of Wo-yu's hand. But it was only one person—it was the receptionist.

“He will come around in 10 minutes,” he said.

Huai-jin thanked him. Wo-yu hugged her tightly, she didn't resist but she was too nervous to hug back either. Without a watch or clock, Huai-jin had no way to tell the time, but she felt she waited for a century. In the silence, she felt she could hear her own heart beating.

The door reopened and a teenager came out. “Hello, what...?” Before he had finished his sentence, his eyes fixed on Huai-jin's face, “You...”

“*Da-ge*,” Huai-jin blurted out the word before she felt too embarrassed to address someone in this way who she was seeing for the first time. She repeated: “*Da-ge*... I am your little sister, the one living with Lin.”

“Ah... it's... it's... you!” *Da-ge* was so surprised that he stuttered. “Why are you here? Anything happened? How have you been these years? You, you...” He seemed unable to figure out where to stand and where to place his hand. Eventually, he sat down on a seat a bit farther from the girls, “What do they call you?”

“Huai-jin,” naturally, she gave this name rather than Lan-zi. “This is my friend, Wo-yu.”

He had noticed Wo-yu from the beginning, but as Huai-jin could feel, he was a bit unsure about how to treat an unfamiliar girl. He nodded at Wo-yu shyly, then commented: “Those sound like fancy names. Have you gone to school? When did you go? Are you still in school? What grade are you in?”

There were too many questions to answer at once. Huai-jin told him that she and Wo-yu just graduated from elementary school and were both admitted to the No.1 middle school³¹ in town.

³¹ Public schools in China are usually numbered within a region. No.1 doesn't refer to a rank, but it is common that No.1 middle/high (usually different departments of one school) school is the best school since it's often the oldest.

“Wait, No.1 Middle School?” *Da-ge*'s voice trembled, out of tune. “The one downtown...? That is so hard. That is Incredible. That is so...impressive.”

The front desk, who heard most of the conversation, also couldn't help cutting in: “Impressive! That is so hard! Especially this year—it was so competitive! Our boss's son —” he lowered his voice, “you know, a lot of our colleagues' families couldn't get in even though they received elementary school education in town.”

After his expressions of ecstasy and pride, *Da-ge* suddenly thought of something: “How do you get the money though? I think your foster family —” He paused there, but Wo-yu knew he was referring to Lin's poor economic and political status.

“I don't have enough money.”

Uttering these words, Huai-jin felt a flush of embarrassment. Now he knew why she was here: not for their family bond, but for money. Before she figured out how to continue, *Da-ge* had already started to speak: “I don't have a lot of money now. If you can wait a bit, I may be able to save ten yuan. I know it's far from enough... you should also ask *Er-di*³²... I mean your *Er-ge*... you've been in touch with him?”

“No, I heard where he worked was very remote.”

“Yes, usually he finds me rather than me finding him. I know his address though; we can send a letter to him. I can pay a little to ask my colleague to help write it...”

“... *Da-ge*, I know how to write.”

Da-ge was stunned for a moment. Meanwhile, faint embarrassment reddened both his and Huai-jin's faces. Huai-jin suppressed a laugh, smiling with dimples instead. In the silence, she held Wo-yu's hand tight. She yearned to gaze longer at her brother but forced her eyes to wander, acting as natural as possible. She sensed he was doing the same, struggling to appear casual.

It was not a bad visit, she thought in her heart.

Huai-jin indeed knew how to write a letter, but she didn't know how to mail it. She and Wo-yu went to the post office together, only to find that it required more money than she had anticipated. Fortunately, the staff, seeing that they were just two kids, were willing to lend them a

³² Er di: second (younger) brother, as Huai-jin's 2nd older brother is a younger brother of her oldest brother.

pen and provided them one-side-damaged paper for free to serve as letter paper. Following their teacher's instructions—beginning with “Dear brother” and concluding with “Sincerely, Xie Huai-jin, your sister” and the date—the girls deliberated over each word. Huai-jin meticulously wrote what would be her first letter.

However, when it came to mailing the letter, they had to pay for the envelope and stamp themselves. Huai-jin only had half the money needed, so Wo-yu opened her wallet and used her limited pocket money to cover the rest, buying an envelope and stamps. The two girls placed the letter in the envelope, neatly affixed the stamp, and dropped it into the mailbox as directed by the staff. Having accomplished a significant task, they both sighed with relief and felt a sense of achievement. Beaming, Huai-jin said to Wo-yu: “Now we know how to write letters. Even if we're not in the same place, we know how to stay in touch!”

A week later, Huai-jin received her *Er-ge*'s response at the quarry. His message was succinct, written with rusty handwriting. He told her that he was very glad to get connected with her and so proud of her getting into the best junior high school. He mentioned that he was taking classes in night school while working as a barber during the day time, and she would be the source of inspiration and encouragement for future study. In the envelope he included all his saved money, hoping that it could help her a bit. All he wished was that she could work hard and get a better life, and that she was willing to help him in the future when she became able to. At the end, she found his strenuously signed name: Xie Zheng-yang.

In the envelope, Huai-jin found various change adding up to around 17 yuan, which was how she could tell how *Er-ge* had saved them bit by bit. That was the first time in her life she had seen so much money.

For the rest of the summer, she worked in the quarry. Her salary added up to around 11 yuan. Her *Da-ge* sponsored her for around 12 yuan; when the summer was about to end, she eventually received the money from her *Er-ge*, which was 17 yuan. These added up to 40 yuan, which could pay her tuition for almost a whole year. However, Chen *Lao-shi* told her that she could lend her a set of textbooks: her eldest son was now in high school, so there were already used textbooks in her household.

On the table, Huai-jin put all the cash she had together. They were all different denominations, so Huai-jin needed to count piece by piece. She counted through them three

times to make sure that her calculation was correct, letting out a deep breath as she realized, half in a dream, that it was.

She could go to school. She was well aware that education was not designed for a kid like her, but she, with the support of the people around her, had made her unrealistic dream come true. She knew the money would be a problem again next year, because her brothers had exhausted their savings from past years, and there would not be another two brothers popping out to share the burden of her tuition. But at least she could study for another long while before she had to worry again.

Huai-jin went to registration in the fall. Stepping into the crowds of students with decent clothes and neat backpacks, Huai-jin silently grabbed her little patched cloth bag tight. She knew that half of the classmates were from the town. Others were boarders—who were here registering with her— mostly from the decent families in the nearby villages. Huai-jin could easily tell them apart from the others, as they mostly carried an additional big bag, accompanied by parents who also carried bags. But all Huai-jin brought with her was the shabby bag that was as big as others' backpacks. She joined the line quietly, afraid that someone would notice her and talk to her. Fortunately, the registration administrators were nice and friendly, treating her just like other students, so she could let down her guard and focus on her move in.

Huai-jin didn't see Wo-yu because day students had a different registration procedure. Indeed, Huai-jin was surprised when she first learned that Wo-yu had chosen to live with her parents in the town: "Living with your parents? Do you really have space?" Huai-jin could still remember the crowdedness of their little apartment; she didn't think any more beds could fit in.

"I will sleep on the floor," said Wo-yu, calmly. "My parents were saving money for my brother. He will be in middle school next year."

Huai-jin was silent. She gave her a hug, the kind of hugs Wo-yu usually offered her. She had met her brother—he was a lucky boy, growing up and going to school in the town, getting the best education his parents could offer. Wo-yu and he were three years apart, but he was only one school year behind because they literally entered elementary school in the same year. Before Chen *Lao-shi* came to the countryside to knock on every door and talk about free elementary education, Wo-yu had stayed at home just like other village girls. Her parents were happy to

spend a little more on her clothing so that she could look more decent than village girls; but when it came to educational investment, they were reluctant to spend a penny.

She had secretly envied Wo-yu's nice clothes. Sometimes she had also darkly rejoiced about the similar solitude that had dragged Wo-yu to the same level as her. But at this moment, she only wanted to hug this girl close and surround her wound with all sincerity and love.

Huai-jin could not spend as much time with Wo-yu in middle school. Each grade was divided into four classes: *Jia*, *Yi*, *Bing*, and *Ding*.³³ Huai-jin was in class *Bing*, while Wo-yu was in class *Yi*. Besides, as a boarder, Huai-jin could no longer commute with Wo-yu after school, just as Wo-yu couldn't take a walk around campus with her in the evening.

Boarding school life was new to Huai-jin. She had never known that life could be so... organized. In the morning, the bell rang to wake up the boarding students. Then the students went down to the playground to do morning exercises. It was a novelty for Huai-jin to see hundreds of the young people doing the same gestures with the teacher shouting the rhythms: "One, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight; two, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight..." At the beginning, Huai-jin was lost and not sure what to do, but with the reminders from classmates who studied in elementary school in town and so were used to the system, she started to follow the pattern of the exercise leader and soon remembered all the movements. She gradually started to enjoy becoming a part of a bigger composite with a sense of belonging, which she had barely experienced before.

After morning exercise, students went to the classroom for individual study. Sometimes, upon the Chinese teacher's request the monitor would lead the whole class in reading aloud articles in the textbook together. The teacher used an old Chinese saying in the textbook to explain the necessity of such a schedule: "The year's plan lies in the spring; the day's plan lies in the morning³⁴." After students read for half an hour, the bell rang again, and the students would be allowed to go to breakfast. The school wasn't very strict about where the students should sit,

³³ 甲乙丙丁 - The first four of Chinese Celestial Stems; usually used for numbering/labeling. Can be understood like A, B, C, D.

³⁴ 一年之计在于春，一日之计在于晨, basically saying that spring is the key moment of a year, and that the morning is a key moment of a day.

so Huai-jin usually sat with Wo-yu—being in different classes now, they didn't have many opportunities to be together.

When they arrived at the dining hall, the food was already on the tables. But when they sat down, they were not allowed to eat right away. After everyone was seated, a student leader would announce “Start eating,” and then the students could eat. When Huai-jin started school life, she was highly impressed by the service they got and found the student leader very admirable and authoritative. She later got to know the concept of “students on duty.” Although the school had staff for cooking and dish-washing, it was the students on duty who allocated the dishes and utensils to every table. It would also be one of the students-on-duty who announced the start of each meal. The meal service was not the only duty; the duty would rotate through the student body from class to class. It started with Class *Jia* of Junior 3³⁵; after going across the four classes of Junior 3, the duty moved to Junior 2. The class on duty would serve the whole campus during the duty week; its classmates would divide up the services, and dining service was one of them.

Breakfast, lunch, and dinner were the most relaxing times for Huai-jin, not only because she could take a break from studying, but also because she enjoyed the food here so much. Although she was bothered by the seven-yuan-per-month dining fee, she couldn't deny that the food in the school dining hall was very good, at least for her: Soymilk and buns for breakfast, white rice with vegetables—sometimes even a bit of minced meat—for lunch and dinner. Those things she could hardly ever enjoy back home.

They had four classes in the morning and two classes in the afternoon, with the ringing of the bell indicating the beginning and end of each designated period. Huai-jin liked to walk to Class *Yi* to visit Wo-yu during class time, as their classrooms were nearby. Sometimes, when she was outside the classroom, she could see through the window that Wo-yu was having fun with other girls, which made her hesitate to call out a greeting.

The post-lunch break, though, was a regular meeting time for Huai-jin and Wo-yu. It was long enough so that the students could take a nap, but they usually used this time to study together. Huai-jin was glad that she was still special to Wo-yu in some way, but that was pretty

³⁵ Junior high schools correspond to grade 7-9; junior 3 = grade 9.

much all the time they could get together. After school ended in the afternoon, Wo-yu had to go home to help prepare dinner, while Huai-jin would study till the dining hall opened for dinner.

After dinner, students went back to the classroom for another three hours of self-study. This was also new to Huai-jin, as the absence of lighting at home didn't allow her to do any work at night. After the self-study period ended, the remaining day students went home, and boarding students went back to their dorm. Curfew was around 20 minutes after they were dismissed from classrooms. As the curfew bell rang, all the lights went out, along with all the sounds. Around twenty girls shared a room with bunk-beds. Huai-jin, visibly lighter than most of the classmates, slept on a top bunk; whenever she turned around, the old wooden bed would make a squeaking noise. So afraid of disturbing the classmates around her, Huai-jin gradually got used to sleeping in a constant supine position. Usually, the tiredness of the day would quickly crawl over her mind and drag her into deep sleep.

Huai-jin quickly adapted to her new life, almost as smoothly as a fledgling bird embracing the sky. According to the words of the teachers, on which she accidentally eavesdropped, she was “born to study well,” and it was just a pity that she came from such a harsh background.

As a boarding student, Huai-jin didn't need to be worried about commuting. Even on Sunday, boarders were not allowed to leave the school without an application and approval from the school. For many boarding students, such strict policies felt oppressive; they experienced loneliness, homesickness, and often needed to seek comfort from their counselors in tears. However, Huai-jin thrived as if in her natural element; especially as she gradually adapted to school life, she increasingly felt that the school was more like her home.

After each monthly exam, every class would calculate the average score and put it along with everyone's individual score, ranking from highest to lowest, outside the door of the classroom. Huai-jin wasn't the top scorer of the class at first, but as soon as she was receiving the same education as every other classmate, she quickly dominated first place. She hardly ever fell into second place—maybe only two or three times during the whole middle school years, as she

remembered. She would also look at other classes' grade list to see where she was at in terms of the whole grade; indeed, she was always in the top 5 out of all of the 200 people, usually in the top 3, sometimes in the first place. She was also proud of the fact that Class *Bing*, where she was, always had the highest average score. That was her earliest notion of competition. Her deep fear of inferiority started to fade as she began to compete at the same level with her privileged classmates. In the school environment, Huai-jin quickly accepted the new set of standards—ones that happened to benefit her.

Her good scores placed her at the center of attention. Teachers all liked to ask her to answer questions in class, as she could always give a comprehensive answer. She enjoyed her classmates' admiring gaze when the teacher approved her answer and used her as an example to inspire others. The teachers treated her like their own children, especially her class's head teacher Li *Lao-shi*, a lady who, as far as Huai-jin could remember, never got married. She lived several steps away from the school alone. Huai-jin sometimes would go to Li *Lao-shi*'s place and help her with chores. Seeing that Huai-jin couldn't afford a towel, Li *Lao-shi* bought one for her.

Her class prefects all liked her because her good grades and academic performance helped their class earn honor. They were generally from the town, born into decent families, and had experience as student leaders since elementary school. They cared for her as delegates of the teachers, helping her adapt to the unfamiliar life in town. Although Huai-jin was older than her classmates, as she started school late, sometimes she felt she was like their little sister. Other classmates, no matter how close they were to her, all respected her. She had seldom felt the same care from her home. She could see that her parents' love wasn't unconditional; they liked her because she was responsible, reliable, and diligent in the housework. Even so, she couldn't get much love from them, because they had work to do and their biological children to care for. As an adopted girl in the village, there was no reason for her to get more attention than others, even though retrospectively, she thought she was the most special one, with her unique persistence in schooling. But in school, she could feel that she was somewhat special. She could feel as though her grades justified her specialness. Because she earned her privileges with effort, she felt she well deserved them, and so to continue deserving them she kept working hard—life fell into a positive cycle of gaining control of her life through education.

She forgot the undeservedness she felt with her old patch bag and embraced the feelings of deservedness—as she did study harder than most of her classmates. This to her was an even more solid source of deservedness, as the benefits she gained originated from her own power—her persistence, her diligence, her intelligence—rather than the factors she couldn't control, such as parents or hometown.

One sad thing for Huai-jin was that she and Wo-yu were no longer able to be considered as a buddy pair everywhere they went, not only because they were in different classes and had different schedules, but also due to the mismatch of their academic performance. After entering middle school, Wo-yu's score became more and more ordinary. Compared to their elementary school, the middle school taught much more material and at a faster pace. Like Huai-jin, Wo-yu had only studied in elementary school for four years. Their knowledge foundation was far less solid than their classmates from town elementary school.

“Wo-yu, you don't have enough time.” Huai-jin eventually spoke out as she witnessed Wo-yu's desperation about study one day.

“I know.” Wo-yu said with a listless voice. “I said it was too much time to commute, but they said it was too high a boarding fee. And they said my brother commutes too.”

But her brother's elementary school, located right in their neighborhood, recruited nearby workers' kids, and didn't even offer a boarding option. But her brother didn't need to help with housework. And her brother's light elementary-school workload didn't need his extra study time.

Huai-jin couldn't think too deeply about it, just as she refused to think deeply about her own plight. She was content with her life as a boarder in this perfect ivory tower that sheltered her from the world she came from. Empathizing with Wo-yu would bring back all the anxiety she tried to forget, reminding her that she was a village girl, that she was still behind in her room and board payment, and that she would have to face another education crisis after this year.

One day, when class finished, when Huai-jin still had her eyes fixed on the textbook, a classmate patted on her shoulder, telling her that someone outside was looking for her.

Huai-jin first thought it was Wo-yu, but she saw a uniformed gatehouse guard, who called her to go to the front-guard room.

“Your brother has come to see you.”

Huai-jin was surprised. She went to the waiting room with the front guard. From afar, she could see that it wasn't her adopted brother from home. Surprised that this man would come and find her, she hid her excitement, calling out tentatively while trotting towards him: “*Da-ge* —”

The young man raised his head. When Huai-jin saw his face clearly, she realized that it wasn't her brother Xie Jian-yang. Before her brain figured out what was going on, the man spoke. “Huai-jin?—I am your *Er-ge*; my name is Xie Zhi-yang.”

This was the first time in Huai-jin's life that she had ever seen her *Er-ge*. Before, they had only exchanged a few messages—and 12 yuan—transferred via short letters. Totally unprepared, she was almost struck dumb. Maybe that was how *Da-ge* felt when he saw her. *Er-ge* was around fifteen; their ages were much closer.

Seeing her brother reminded her of the upperclassmen in the school. They were almost the same age, but while her schoolmates were sitting in the classroom and worrying about their studies, her *Er-ge* was struggling to work and feed himself and support his sister. It was almost as if they and *Er-ge* inhabited two different worlds, and Huai-jin found herself somewhere in between. When she was with classmates, she identified with them as a student, but when she saw her brother, she remembered that she was always that village girl.

Er-ge was more talkative than *Da-ge*. The fifteen minutes between classes were far from enough for them to talk. That day, instead of napping or studying with Wo-yu, Huai-jin spent her noon break with her brother and got to know about the experience of her two brothers after she was sent away at a young age.

When the step-mother came and Huai-jin was sent to Lin, the two boys were only two and four. Before they could make any contribution to the family, the step-mother had already given birth to a son and therefore gained the dominant voice of the family. Their step-mother didn't mistreat them, but as their age was close to her own sons, she had obvious favor for her own son over them. When her children gradually grew up, it became a bigger nightmare, especially for *Er-ge*, whose age was closer to them. The boys who were born to their step-mother liked to bully *Er-ge*, but the parents hardly ever took *Er-ge's* side. After their father lost most of

his property during land reformation, feeding all the kids became difficult. Therefore, their father decided to send the boys to apprenticeships, so they would no longer consume the resources of the household.

Er-ge said: “It was also an opportunity for us. We were not happy at home anyway, and there was nothing we could do. We know that our father wants to leave most of his legacy to that woman's sons, no matter what we do. It was better that we could jump out of that box. We are boys. We can fight and earn our future by ourselves. Honestly, when we went back to visit, even that woman treated us a bit better because we were no longer competing with her sons.”

The brothers didn't go to school; they were the oldest children in the family, so they took most of the work when living at home. Their half-siblings did go to school for a while, but they, like most other village kids, didn't persist. After going into town, the brothers realized the importance of education. Luckily, their workplace offered free evening school, where the workers could go after work to learn some basic elementary-school-level knowledge. Currently, they had already developed some basic reading and writing and math skills; they could communicate with each other by writing letters now.

“But you are the most advanced among all of us. I am so proud of you.” *Er-ge* was so excited when talking about her, which made Huai-jin a bit shy.

When *Er-ge* was about to leave, he sorted out some wrinkled paper notes and coins, trying to give them to Huai-jin. Huai-jin's face suddenly reddened and hid her hands behind her back, as she was so uncomfortable about taking them— they just met each other for the first time! *Er-ge* eventually left the money on the table of the meeting room. After he left, Huai-jin carefully picked it up and kept it in her pocket.

With this money, Huai-jin successfully submitted the overdue boarding fees of the last two months. Many times, when she indulged in school life, the idea of unpaid fees flashed through her peaceful mind like lightning. Now, without any debt to school, Huai-jin felt like the other students again. This was the first time she felt that she was not inferior to her classmates even in terms of her personal background: she also had a family to support her.

Huai-jin began to lose her time with Wo-yu during the noon break.

It didn't happen with no prior warning. At first, Wo-yu would go to Class *Jia* to meet Huai-jin in the morning, telling her that she wouldn't make the noon break because she was too busy, or too tired and in need of a nap. Then not coming became a default; once in a while Huai-jin would receive Wo-yu's message, usually passed through a classmate, that she could make the noon break. And then the frequency of such messages decreased as the semester went.

Huai-jin got used to studying alone during noon break. Sometimes, when she was eating alone in the dining hall, thinking about the boredom and loneliness of studying alone after lunch, her heart sank. But when she walked back and stood in front of the classroom, seeing her name at the top of the rosters, she felt relieved.

One day while studying in the classroom she thought about Wo-yu. She walked to class *Yi* to find out what Wo-yu was doing, wishing to take her to study together. Through the window, she saw Wo-yu sleeping on the desk. She stood there watching Wo-yu nap for a while. Seeing that there was no sign she would wake up, she turned around and headed back.

That was not the only time she checked on Wo-yu during the noon break. When Huai-jin looked through the window, sometimes she was napping, sometimes she was not there. One time, Wo-yu was chatting with a group of girls; when Huai-jin went by, she happened to laugh out loud. Frowning, Huai-jin didn't call out to her as she planned but instead returned to her own classroom. After that, she didn't go to see Wo-yu during noon break again.

That was the part of Wo-yu that Huai-jin couldn't understand— why she, already with such limited time, wasted the crucial noon break—why she indulged in chatting with other classmates, since with good grades alone one could harvest everyone else's respect—why she still found other friends, all of whom combined could not provide as much support as her.

But she did not ask.

Er-ge visited Huai-jin whenever he had any kind of a short break—the hydropower station where he worked was close to Huai-jin's school. They became closer and closer. Every time he came, he would give Huai-jin a few yuan to pay the boarding fee; after Huai-jin got used

to the fact that they were brother and sister, the closest people in the world, she dared to take his money from his hands, and she vowed to herself that she would work hard and reward this dear brother in the future.

Indeed, Huai-jin could already do something for her *Er-ge*. Although there was a free evening school in the hydropower station, it wasn't taught in a structured way. Their teachers were not as good as the ones teaching in Huai-jin's school, and the teachers usually came and went. Besides, as an apprentice, *Er-ge* couldn't make every class. When he visited Huai-jin, he also asked her academic questions.

As they talked more, Huai-jin knew that *Er-ge* wanted to be an engineer. It was quite natural—as he worked as a barber by a hydropower station, most of *Er-ge's* clients were workers in the station; he developed connections with them and became familiar with how the industry worked. But to enter the system, he needed to pass its exams, which included geometry, a subject not taught in evening school. Once Huai-jin found that out, she borrowed her textbooks for him to read when she was in other classes; whenever she had a break, she came to the greeting room to tutor him, answering his questions.

She loved when she watched his head bent over the book, searching through questions to ask, as the bugs irregularly circled in the greeting room's light. These moments recharged her and eased her long-felt solitude, even though sometimes they didn't exchange more than a handful of phrases.

When *Er-ge* got any helpful books, he would also share them with Huai-jin. When Huai-jin first told Wo-yu about that, she could see that Wo-yu was sincerely happy for her growth. But when she, with enthusiasm, tried to share the books with Wo-yu, Huai-jin spotted the disinterested attitude behind her politeness and kindness. She felt that invisible wall again between her and Wo-yu, and she was not sure if she should try to cross it.

It was the first winter break and first new year Huai-jin had after going to middle school. For the first time, she had to spend it without Wo-yu—who stayed in town with her

family—since they had known each other. The good thing was that when *Er-ge* learned of her situation one week before the break he promised to accompany her back home.

He came with his new bike to pick up his sister. They started walking along the newly built road, pushing the bike along. After a mile or so, there was a bike station. *Er-ge* rented another bike for Huai-jin. As far as Huai-jin could remember, before that, she had only ridden a bike once. During the week-long National Day break in October, *Er-ge* and *Da-ge* came to spend time with her. They went to the town stadium to learn biking. After that, Huai-jin did not get another chance to learn biking, while the two brothers, who had more flexible schedules, had been back several times.

Huai-jin wasn't scared though; her courage came from her confidence in her own athletic ability. She was then not even fifteen, and weighed less than 40 kg. She was light and nimble, playing Forward for her class basketball team. When she took the ball and shuttled it across to teammates, she moved swiftly like a swallow and ran fast like swirling wind. She successfully got on the bike and pedaled, like she had before. Following *Er-ge*, she traveled back to her village on the bike pretty smoothly.

Yet when she got close to her village, there was a rather long downhill. The bike rolled faster and faster even without her pedaling, and she didn't know what to do. It happened to be a windy day; she felt the wind flogging her ears, making such a wuthering sound that she could barely hear anything.

"I'm gonna die! I'm gonna die!" Huai-jin cried out, her voice distorted in the wind.

Er-ge, to keep up with his sister, didn't slow down either. He shouted as loud as he could: "Not a big deal! Press your brake! Your brake! Press it! You will be ok!"

In that moment Huai-jin couldn't remember what a brake was. She could only try to stay calm and concentrate on balancing herself; she was so focused that she forgot to shout. She gripped the handlebar very hard, her entire body was so tight with nervousness. At the next fork in the road, she used her last ounce of courage and presence of mind to ride up the steep hill. The bike gradually slowed down. Before it started downhill again, she jumped off. She skipped for several steps, and the bike eventually stopped. A few seconds later, *Er-ge* caught up, braking, and stopped by her side. In each other's eyes, they saw worry, fear, and the thrill of adventure that belongs only to teenagers.

One day, when meeting *Er-ge*, Huai-jin saw a familiar woman in the front gate meeting room. She couldn't recall who it was for a moment, but as she encountered Wo-yu in the staircase when she walked back to the classroom, she realized that the woman was Wo-yu's mother. She did not think much about it at the time, but when she looked back at that encounter many years later, she saw a chasm between Wo-yu and her. She and Wo-yu were both walking towards a staircase, but she was going upwards while Wo-yu was going downwards. Her eyes tried to stay longer on that familiar face, but Wo-yu's eyes quickly avoided her as if burnt by her gaze. And the staircase had a theme that Huai-jin could feel but couldn't name—maybe “family”—maybe “education”—maybe “fate.” Whenever she recalled this ten-second passing by, it felt much, much longer.

Huai-jin earned first place in her grade in the final exam of her first semester—making her name known by the whole school. Everyone knew that the first place was a girl who came from a village. Li *Lao-shi* found her and said with pity that Huai-jin could get a great municipal level honor with scholarship had she not come from a “rich farmer” family. Huai-jin remembered how desperate she felt when Chen *Lao-shi* said the similar thing to her; but now she was used to it.

After the first year, Huai-jin started to owe money to the school. She slowly repaid her debts with the money her brothers sent, but her pace of repayment could not keep up with the speed at which her debt grew. For students like her, who fell behind on payments, the dining hall would not withhold meals nor would the dormitory expel them; however, a small blackboard at the entrance of the dining hall clearly displayed who owed how much. Each time she saw her name, “Xie Huai-jin,” written in bold, her face would flush with embarrassment. She wasn't concerned about people talking behind her back, but the fear of being pointed at and discussed to her face was daunting. Thus, during busy times, she entered the dining hall with her head down,

fearing recognition and immediate association with the names and debts listed on the board. Once when Huai-jin was helping out in Li *Lao-shi*'s place, Li *Lao-shi* asked her: "You will keep coming to school, right?"

Huai-jin was wiping the table. She paused for a moment. "Right," she said with conviction, though she didn't know where that conviction came from. After a second, she asked: "May I have an extension for my boarding fees? I will eventually pay all of them. I swear."

"I know it is difficult..." Li *Lao-shi* sighed, "I know it is very difficult, but..."

She didn't finish.

Li *Lao-shi* had been to Huai-jin's place in the summer. She was visiting students' homes, and Huai-jin's was the farthest away from school. When she arrived, she was stunned. Everyone's clothes were old and patched. Because there was one more family member after her brothers' wedding, and also because Huai-jin barely went back after going to middle school, she didn't have a room right now, only a corner in the storage area to sleep. When Huai-jin's adopted parents fed Li *Lao-shi*, they offered hot steamed sweet potato, which was almost the only food they had. They explicitly told Li *Lao-shi* that they could not pay anything for Huai-jin. Both daughter-in-laws were pregnant, which to them was a much more important event than Huai-jin's education.

The living picture of Huai-jin's family must have been very astonishing for the young teacher. A-Zhang and her husband were around 17; for her students, it was still an age for high school or university education, but for the young farmers, that was when their phase of dependent early life ended; they were considered adults, because the requirements for adult farmers were much lower than that for adult intellectuals. They would repeat similar lives from then on until their death.

When Huai-jin herself became a teacher many years later, she could understand how Li *Lao-shi* felt then. When you saw a gem, as a teacher and as a human, you would not want it to sink into the dust and dirt.

Li *Lao-shi* took Huai-jin to the school secretary. She described what she saw in Huai-jin's home and what she knew about Huai-jin's financial struggles at school; she told of the great contribution Huai-jin made to the class and the school and how much potential Huai-jin had to

contribute to the nation in the future. She asked if administration could make a certificate of her poverty, so the financial department could allow Huai-jin to pay after she worked.

The secretary seemed to be easy-going, but when he saw from the document that Huai-jin was a “rich farmer”, he pointed the finger at it and shook his head, “Sorry, I couldn't make a certificate for her. Her *Cheng-fen* was high.”

“But her family is truly poor. If you visit her home, you can see that I made no exaggeration about her situation...”

“That is not the issue,” the secretary cut her off. “High *Cheng-fen* is very sensitive. Please understand me—I can't take the responsibility. I can't afford the risk. No one can.”

Huai-jin had anticipated the result. She was ready for the worst, but she felt so bad to implicate her dear teacher into this dilemma.

Yet two days later, Li *Lao-shi* told Huai-jin not to be worried, as she had figured something out. She didn't realize until the next semester that Li *Lao-shi*'s solution was to use the excess class fees to pay for Huai-jin's owed tuition. That was not legal, but because it came from good intentions and had no real consequences, the leaders mostly turned a blind eye. But Li *Lao-shi* was still criticized, and as a punishment she lost her well-deserved teaching honor for the year. What happened eventually came to Huai-jin's ears.

Huai-jin felt terrible, but Li *Lao-shi* comforted her: “It is just one year for me, but it would be your whole life for you.”

Wo-yu stopped showing up to school.

It took Huai-jin several days to realize what had happened. She did notice Wo-yu's absence, but she didn't consider the possibility that Wo-yu had quit school, until she got the information from Wo-yu's classmates.

“No way.” Huai-jin was astonished, unable to control her reaction. Visiting class *Yi*, Huai-jin asked whether Wo-yu's day student classmates could help pass the notes she took to Wo-yu. She was confident that no one could help Wo-yu more than her—her notes were popular materials among her classmates.

Her eyes were wide open, her tone was distorted by aggressiveness. The student she asked was slightly upset and embarrassed, but she still tried to answer politely:

“It's not a secret at all. If you don't believe us, you can ask her yourself.”

Huai-jin knew that was not actually meant to be an encouragement for her to ask Wo-yu, but she still decided to go to Wo-yu's place. She knew it was a crazy thing to do; appearing at someone's door without an invitation was impolite, or even rude. But now she craved a confrontation—which she tried to avoid for a long time. She needed to ask Wo-yu what she was doing. She *needed* to hear her answer, although before she went to ask, she already partly believed what the classmate said.

So she went for it. She filled out the application form to leave the school grounds, with the lie that her *Da-ge* was inviting her *Er-ge* for a dinner on Friday night. No one would disapprove of such an ordinary request from a model student who barely left campus during the semester. So on Friday, she went out with the day students after school finished, following the path in her memory, and knocked on the familiar door on the first floor.

It was Huai-jin's mother who opened the door—many years later, Huai-jin still remembered.

She remembered her mom calling her “Pan-di.”

She remembered her mom said, “Make your conversation quick. *She's different.*”

She remembered Wo-yu appeared with two braids and her regular dress, just like before.

She remembered that her dark eyes reflected the fragmented light of the setting sun, absorbing nothing in, as if nothing could go into her heart. As Huai-jin's gaze became intense, she lowered eyelids to avoid eye contact.

“Why did you come?” Wo-yu asked eventually, after the stressful silence.

“I haven't seen you recently.” After uttering the first word, Huai-jin felt she finally recalled what she wanted to say and why she had come, “Somebody said you quit school, but I don't believe it. It cannot be true, you...”

“It is true.”

Huai-jin was a bit surprised that Wo-yu cut her off, but what struck her more was what she heard. She lost her voice for a moment. She had thought she was ready to hear the answer, but she wasn't. Wo-yu was right there in front of her, demure as always, but she seemed to look much more reserved today. She was avoiding eye contact; Huai-jin could only see her long eyelashes trembling. Huai-jin could barely assemble a thought, and it was only after several moments that she eventually uttered a word, though she found her voice unusually hoarse: "...Why?"

Wo-yu was reluctant to respond, but looking at Huai-jin standing in front of the door like a tree, she didn't know what to do either. She turned her head to look back, checking if her mother could hear their conversation. And then she resigned herself to Huai-jin: "Can we talk somewhere else? At the corner of that lane?"

Huai-jin could not say no. During their short trip to that corner, Huai-jin felt like saying many things, but she didn't. She was naive, but she was not clueless. She thought she and Wo-yu were close enough that they could say anything, but now she was not sure what was proper to say. Along the way, Wo-yu avoided conversation as well.

When they arrived, Huai-jin broke the silence first: "Why? We promised each other, right? We will go to a university. We will live in cities."

"Those are obviously childish fantasies. I am sorry that you treated them seriously."

Huai-jin felt as if she had crashed into a cotton mattress, blocking off all her questions. She was rendered speechless, trembling. Her mind was almost a blank; she could only repeat what she had already asked:

"Why?... Why?"

"Why do you ask why?... It's obvious. I'm not smart enough."

"Why are you saying that?" Huai-jin was confused, "you are better than half of our classmates! Chen *Lao-shi* said you can totally get into a high school."

"I could not afford that."

"... Come on, even I can struggle to make it through. My parents don't sponsor me even a penny; your parents can at least pay some part of it."

"Your biological brothers support you, but my family will not pay for an incapable daughter."

“... Don't use those words to describe yourself. You are surely capable.”

“My academics are just mediocre.”

“You have more potential than that. You can do it! As long as you work a little harder. I can help you! You can ask teachers for help and support too. My headteacher Li *Lao-shi* helped with my financial pressure.”

“... also, I don't have time.”

“You have time! You just need to use it well. I saw you wasting quite a lot of it. If you can stay studying during noon break like me...”

“Please stop talking!” Wo-yu raised her voice. The always gentle and demure Wo-yu. Huai-jin was stunned, forgetting to even react. Before Huai-jin knew what to do, Wo-yu said: “Sorry, I have to go home now.”

Huai-jin saw her turn around and trot, her black braids bouncing upon her back, bound with the red ribbons which danced and flickered in her vision. She watched her becoming smaller and smaller in her view and disappearing at the corner. She didn't stop her. She didn't know what to do.

PART II

Huai-jin, cradling a heart entangled in complex emotions, returned to her solitary dormitory with the stationery and envelopes she just bought this afternoon. At this time of the day, she was the room's sole occupant, the solitary sovereign of her own domain. She approached her desk and, with meticulous care, sorted through the pile of students' exercise books awaiting her red pen to craft a serene and orderly void in the midst of cluttered academia. With deliberation that bordered on the ceremonial, she unfurled the pristine paper across the desk.

She caressed her most treasured fountain pen, uncapping it with reverence. But then, confronted by the expanse of virgin paper, she found herself adrift in uncertainty. In days past, writing to her had been as natural as breathing. On the rough draft paper, with a stub of poor-quality pencil, her thoughts would flow like a waterfall, words spilling out from the pen tip, filling the pages with practiced fluidity. Now, with the pen of her dreams in hand and facing such fine paper, she felt paralyzed, with all the words dammed up within her.

Her conversation earlier that day with Ying-zi, the girl from the Grade 4, Class 3, had an air of the surreal that lingered still. The person from whom she had struggled to glean even a hint of news, the person she thought had vanished from her life, had now unexpectedly stepped back into her orbit. The unreachable correspondent she had so desperately sought—the nebulous connection she had poured her soul into—had suddenly taken on tangible form.

The fleeting intermission between classes had whirled by, during which she had only managed to hastily inquire about Ying-zi's *Sao-sao's* wellbeing and glean a sketchy outline of her

recent years. Knowing the class bell was about to ring, her multitude of unsaid words crystallized into a single plea—

“Could you deliver a letter to your *Sao-sao* for me when she returns home with your *Ge-ge* from the military?”

The little girl nodded in response to Huai-jin's expectant gaze.

So, Huai-jin, with the solemnity of preparing for a ritual, had selected the most elegant stationery and envelopes from the grocery store and hastened back to her room after work, intent on composing this letter with due gravity. Yet, now the moment had arrived, she was struck mute—her heart brimmed with a thousand words, yet it felt as though she had none at all.

She replaced the cap on her pen, the crisp click resonating in the silent room.

After sitting motionlessly at the desk for a long while, she stood and slowly opened the bottom drawer of the cabinet. There, nestled within, lay past correspondence, and in the furthest corner, a stack of papers, neither thick nor thin. Huai-jin tenderly extracted them.

The paper, not high quality to begin with, had softened and wrinkled after two years. The pencil marks had smudged slightly, yet the words remained discernible. Huai-jin's thumb gently grazed the corner of the page, each stroke a silent testament to the memories etched thereon. Huai-jin's eyes scanned over the contents of the papers, page by page, neatly arranging them before placing them back in the corner of the drawer.

These letters, written by Huai-jin after 1961, had never been sent. So now she could now dig them out to review her moods when they had been written. But before them, she had sent out many letters, all lost in the turbulence of time. Whether they had even reached the intended recipient, Huai-jin never knew. She needed to think hard, with her eyes closed, to recall the stories behind those letters she had put into envelopes, stamped, and dropped into the mailbox.

“Dear Wo-yu,” Huai-jin had written painstakingly on the paper. At that time, she had just started at the Teacher's School and was using a spare ballpoint pen borrowed from a classmate. The pen was somewhat old, its ink flow not the best, requiring her to press down hard to produce smooth script.

“How is everything with you? It's been a week since the start of school here, and I've basically adapted to the environment and figured out how to send and receive mail. I plan to write to you every month; I think you will just read my letters but if you could reply, I would be very touched.”

It was not her first time writing a letter to Wo-yu. During her Junior 3, While she was still in town and was living no more than a few streets from Wo-yu, writing and delivering a paper to Wo-yu was a part of her biweekly Friday routine. She gradually realized that Wo-yu regularly did errands for her family on Friday evenings, so when she had a letter, she would stop Wo-yu on her way and hand her what she wrote. Honestly, it wasn't always a letter; sometimes she would hand her important academic notes, hoping that she could feed Wo-yu some knowledge this way.

But this time, it was different; she used to write Wo-yu because that was her most comfortable way of communicating. She tried more than once to confront Wo-yu, but Wo-yu usually dodged her, avoiding any eye contact. It was hard for Huai-jin to say anything to Wo-yu given her evasive manner.

But now, as she graduated and left the town, writing became the only way that Huai-jin could possibly reach her. When she had so many things to share, she could only leave them on the paper and trust that they would reach the person she was thinking of.

“The Normal School I'm attending is really spacious and beautiful. The teachers say it used to be a rehabilitation school for disabled soldiers, hence the large grounds. It was later converted into the campus buildings and playing fields for our teacher training institute. All our activity spaces are within a large field, including basketball courts and areas for long jump and high jump—everything one could need. Although I haven't seen many schools, I have seen a few, and none are as flat and even as this one. The classrooms are all on a single level, the paths are made of compacted gravel, very flat, and the school buildings are very beautiful and large.

“We have over a dozen classes, and just like in our middle school, there is time for physical exercises every day. When the time comes and the bell rings, over a dozen classes line up and go down to the big field to do radio exercises and group dances. The school is very large and completely flat, a vast plain. My dormitory is very spacious, almost as big as a small classroom, and with me included, only three people sleep there. The cafeteria is also very big, and the food is good.

“The most shocking thing is that we have a real auditorium—one that can seat a thousand people. The seniors say that the nearby officials come to our auditorium for meetings. So often at night, there are opera performances in the auditorium, artists invited by the leaders, singing Beijing opera in a very authentic style, slightly different from what our generation is used to. This week I saw a performance, the singing was better than any I've heard before, and it carries so far, I can hear it from the dormitory.

“At the moment, our lives are very regular, we get up early in the morning—as soon as the bell rings we have to get up quickly. My basin got damaged on the bus ride here, but my roommates are quite friendly. Since the water tap is far away, I've arranged with one roommate that I'll get up earlier to borrow her basin to wash my face first, and then I'll bring back a basin of water for her so she can sleep in a bit and doesn't have to run that far. It's tough to linger in bed in the morning, after washing up, we have to hurry to do the radio exercises, otherwise, because the dormitory is a distance from the big field, we have to run, and being late isn't good.

“During the breaks, we all have to dance a group dance, each class forming circles in the field. It's similar to what we did in middle school, but with more people and a bigger space, it's even more lively. As for classes, the schedule is all set, quite similar to middle school. Since everyone boards at the school, we all go to two study sessions in the evening; after that, the lights stay on for students who want to study longer, as long as they make it back to the dorm before curfew.

“Wo-yu, I wonder how your life is now. Although you've been staying at home doing housework for over a year, I assume that's just a temporary measure? Once you have the opportunity, I think it would be good for you to come out and see things. Although I haven't seen as many nice things as you have, I bet you've never seen a campus as large as the Normal School I'm attending now. If the Normal School is like this, I can only imagine how grand a university campus must be! Unfortunately, I won't have the chance to see that.

Wishing you all the best,

Huai-jin

September 6, 1958

Dear Wo-yu,

I've met an older lady at the teacher's college—I call her Xiu-mei *Jie*. At first, I didn't realize she was a student. You know, I'm already older than most of my classmates, and she looked older than me. Later, I learned that she's already married. Her educational foundation was not very strong; her husband, who's also her childhood friend, recently became a minor leader at the factory. She came to study to keep pace with him. Many say she got in through the back door, and perhaps that's true. But seeing her study so earnestly every day, working hard in the study hall at night, I can't help but respect her dedication.

Initially, we only knew each other from seeing each other at evening self-study sessions, but after my essay was praised by the teacher in class, Xiu-mei *Jie* tactfully asked if I'd be willing to tutor her, offering to compensate me knowing my financial situation. I gladly accepted.

Now, I tutor her every day, and she indeed provides me with many useful things. At the very least, I don't have to worry about stationery anymore, nor do I lack envelopes and stamps to write to you. She also gave me some of her old clothes which are actually better than most of what I've worn before.

However, she's not very bright. To be honest, Wo-yu, you're much smarter than she is. Her educational background is weak, especially in math. Some calculations she doesn't understand are ones you knew in the first year of junior high. When I first taught her, I was worried she'd be discouraged by too many setbacks and give up. But over the past month, she's still been studying every day, often coming to me for extra lessons. She's made significant progress in the latest exam.

Wo-yu, what I want to say is, you really could consider returning to school. I'm not sure about other schools, but the teacher's college is open to social candidates, and I think if you review a little, you could pass the entrance exam. If you have any problems with your studies, I can tutor you. The courses here are not hard; even Xiu-mei *Jie* can keep up. If you put in a little effort, there will be no problem at all. Whatever help you need, as long as I can do it, I'm willing to give it to you.

My dearest Wo-yu... we had a promise, remember? Do you no longer want to go to the big city? Your family calls you "Pan-di," do you want to give up being "Wo-yu"? Although you told me it was just the childish talk of your youth, I know it wasn't true. You must have faced a lot of pressure back then, and you just wanted me to stop pressuring you—Sorry, I was too immature back then. Now, I just want to tell you to try again—don't put too much pressure on yourself, but give it another shot. Back then, you told me I should strive for what I truly want. I know you gave up your dreams for a reason, but it's not too late to try again now.

Missing you,

Huai-jin

October 4, 1958

In the faculty dorm, Huai-jin opened her eyes and reached out her fingers into the air, as if trying to touch something that didn't exist—she didn't know what. Perhaps it was those letters that had been sent out, lost in the passage of time and space; perhaps it was the memories she struggled to recall; perhaps it was the distant past, a time she could never return to.

As she recalled events from the past, space and time seemed to blur. She could almost remember the feeling of the evening breeze gently blowing on her face as she had walked to the auditorium after dinner, carrying the scent of the night yet warmed by the setting sun; but in a blink of an eye, she seemed to become a passerby again, seeing the young girl from years ago in the empty corridor of the auditorium, taking out letters from the envelope, sorting through them, and putting back those that didn't belong to her.

She knew Wo-yu wouldn't reply to her letters. Even when she was still in junior high in the town so she could occasionally hand Wo-yu the letters in person, Wo-yu would silently accept them, never to respond.

But she still harbored a tiny glimmer of hope in her heart, allowing that hope to become the faint color of joy she grasped onto every day during her time at the Teaching School. So she could at least believe that those letters reached and were read by the one she intended.

Still, indeed, just as she expected, Wo-yu had never replied to her letters.

There was one moment of hope during those days in the Autumn. After dinner, as usual, Huai-jin went to the auditorium. The hallway was silent, and there was no one in sight. Huai-jin found the mail pouch and started to take out the letters one by one, squinting in the dim light to see the names on them.

She went through the letters, setting aside one with her roommate's name on it. When she got to the last letter, to her surprise, she found her own name on it. In that instant, Huai-jin felt as if she had been struck by lightning, and time seemed to stop. Her eyes moved upwards, and she saw the name of the sender: Xie Jian-yang, her *Da-ge*.

After putting the others' letters back into the pouch, Huai-jin opened the letter, and some loose cash fell out, totaling a little over five yuan. She unfolded the letter, recognizing her brothers' handwriting.

It was a joint letter.

Er-ge had applied to be a worker of the prospecting team and successfully got accepted. *Da-ge* had passed the entrance exam to the local nursing school, starting to work towards a degree. They especially thanked Huai-jin for tutoring them during her middle school time, recognizing that their literacy helped a lot in their admission.

Before Huai-jin could feel excited and happy for then, she saw in the concluding lines that they apologized for no longer being able to send money to her, as *Da-ge* needed to support himself, and *Er-ge*, despite getting into a profession with much greater potential and better welfare, for a number of years his salary rate would be lower than the barber job he was working before.

They explained that *Da-ge* had waited until this year to go to nursing school because he knew Huai-jin would rely on his financial support less with the free tuition and stipend from teaching school. *Er-ge* had not planned to apply; but when the prospective team announced their recruitment plan, he knew he should not miss it, as no one knew when they would recruit here again.

Putting down the letters, Huai-jin's heart was filled with complex emotions, intertwining together like knots that she couldn't untangle.

She knew this was the best outcome for her two brothers. She knew they had always yearned to transfer their rural household registration to the county town—despite years of hard work in the town, they still held rural registrations, lacking the benefits of urban residents. They couldn't acquire real estate there, nor could they easily find wives. The prospecting team could transfer *Er-ge's* household registration to the city, a rare opportunity indeed; her *Da-ge*, with the education he received, like her, would also secure a job after graduation and resolve his household registration issue. She was genuinely proud and happy for her two brothers. In a way, they, the three siblings who had nothing but each other yet still strived for a better life, were true companions on the same journey.

But it also meant that they each had their own paths to tread now; her brothers had to focus on their own careers and couldn't spare much thought for her anymore—they must surely support her in their hearts, just as she supported them in hers, but for a long time, they wouldn't be able to do much for each other. Although they were the closest blood relatives, they still couldn't accompany each other for the sake of their own futures. So—she wondered—what about Wo-yu? What was it that she truly desired from pushing Wo-yu?

Dear Wo-yu,

How are you? I hope all is well. Truth be told, I know you won't reply. A few days ago, I received a letter and was momentarily startled, thinking it was from you; but it turned out to be from my brothers. My *Da-ge* got into the nursing school, and my *Er-Ge* was recruited by the prospecting team. I am so happy that they are achieving a bright future with their hard work. Wo-yu, honestly, that could be you too—I am not going to say too much, but I still want to assure you that it is possible.

I've given up on expecting a reply from you! Yet, I still hope to know about your well-being. It's been a long time since I last saw you. Our last encounter was when I left for

teaching school, wasn't it? I knew it was you. But I only caught a brief glimpse of you from the bus and didn't get a chance to speak to you. In the stillness of the night, I often ponder how you are now. I can feel that the fresh environment and life here are transforming me into a different person. Our teachers have even taught us to play the piano—the very large black instrument we once saw in textbook illustrations. Now, I can play a melody on it smoothly. You have never seen me play the piano; I truly hope that one day, I will be able to play it for you.

In essence, I feel that since arriving at the teaching school, many of my opinions and behaviors have changed. I muse over how much of your life I've missed, and how you must have changed a lot too. How much of you is still the same, and how much is unknown to me now? The thought that we might fail to recognize each other when we meet again fills me with sorrow. Could it be that we who were once inseparable... that's why I long to write more letters, to make you aware of my current situation, to involve you in my life. Maybe, I am deluding myself. I suppose I am a burden—perhaps you have already made better friends, or you might even have a boyfriend.

I don't know why, but although you never reply, I am certain that if you receive my letters, you will read them earnestly. I have this trust in you that I can place my heart in your hands without fear of it being shattered, as you have always been such a gentle and kind person. You are always so kind and gentle to everyone, no one wishes to let you down. This, while moving, also frustrates me. You deserve a better life; why resign so easily? Now, I can only silently hope that those around you treat you well and do not fail you.

Wo-yu, I feel so lonely. I do think I have many friends here, the teachers like me, I am willing to help others, and they are happy to help me; most of the time, I feel warm in such an environment, but occasionally, in the deep silence of the night, I realize that we are different. Most of the students here come from towns and cities, a few from the countryside, but none as poor or with a background as tainted as mine. Our past and future paths are not the same.

Wo-yu, over the years, you are the only one who has truly resonated with my heart. In my most distressed moments, I still think of you, imagining you by my side, even though I know that the you that exists now must be different from the you in my memories.

Still missing you,

Huai-jin

November 15, 1958

Dear Wo-yu,

The semester has ended, but I am still at school. The ticket home is too expensive and now that my brothers have stopped sending money, I truly can't afford it. But I don't think it matters anyway, because whether I stay at school or go home, either way I'll be lonely. One of my brothers has gone to medical school, and the other is on a study program with his work unit. I'm not sure I'd see them even if I went back. Perhaps my biggest regret is not seeing you—but then, I don't even know your current situation; maybe you've moved too. Even if you haven't, maybe you wouldn't want to see me.

This semester, on the whole, was quite pleasant; I met people from all over the province and learned many new things. Although I haven't found a friend like you here, I get along well with everyone. My homeroom teacher has been particularly kind to me, taking good care of me; he tells me with my 'bad origins'—speaking of my poor *Cheng-fen*—it's important to learn more to have better prospects. He encouraged me to learn the piano and even got me a spot at the radio station, where I'm responsible for broadcasting during the lunchtime slot once a week. They don't pay students, but I've learned a lot that I wouldn't have had the chance to learn otherwise.

Regrettably, Xiu-mei *Jie* said she won't be coming back next semester. She's pregnant and her in-laws want her to return home to have the child and take care of the household. When I asked if she would finish her studies later, she responded with silence, which I take to mean she likely won't.

Before leaving, she distributed many of her belongings among the students, giving me the most. Among them was a pair of used shoes, made of sturdy fabric with hard, new material soles—apparently called *Su-jiao*³⁶. They're a bit big for me, but I stuff some cloth into the toes and they're fine. These are the best shoes I've ever worn, yet I would have preferred she stayed to study, and I didn't get these shoes. While my relationship with her couldn't compare to what you and I had, she was the person I spent the most time with at this school. I suppose I'll be even lonelier after she's gone.

Best wishes,

Huai-jin

February 2, 1959

Dear Wo-yu,

I hope everything is well with you. We've recently stopped having classes and have been mobilized for steelmaking, following directives from above. We've been assigned to build blast furnaces, carry ore, and operate the bellows for steel production, alternating between day and night shifts. I'm exhausted every day, whether working mornings or nights. Perhaps due to the night shifts, our sleep is irregular, and I'm even more fatigued than when I worked in the quarry. Carrying ore is the most exhausting; sometimes I want to sleep after just a few steps, and my eyelids feel especially heavy when I sit down to rest.

It's been a long time since I've been in touch with my family, and I wonder how things are now in the village. I've heard that the farmers in the surrounding rural areas are no longer farming; instead, they've been collecting all the iron implements, pots, and whatnot from their homes for steel production. They aren't cooking for themselves either, as everyone eats in communal dining halls. I wonder how you've been affected.

Some students have dropped out, including several from my hometown; among them is A Huang from our middle school's *Ding* class—he's from our town, you might run into him. I feel

³⁶ Su jiao: 塑胶, plastic

it's a pity for them, having studied for a semester already; especially the seniors who left in their second year, I really don't understand how they made such a decision. After all, they were halfway through their studies and could have held on to get their diploma. These days are indeed hard to endure, but they can be survived. Some teachers encouraged us that the situation shouldn't always be like this, and in the end, students will have to return to their studies.

I find myself missing the regular class days. How joyful learning is! Even when studying was exhausting, it was sweet. Sometimes I wonder, what did you feel when you first left school?

Lately, I've been too tired to think about much. Life repeats day after day; apart from growing more fatigued and some classmates leaving, there's no change—nothing much to tell. I've heard that the mail delivery is even slower now, so I don't know when you will receive this letter. I can only wish you all the best.

Missing you,

Huai-jin

March 3, 1959

The first year seemed to rapidly flow by. In the summer, Huai-jin chose to stay on campus when schoolmates were returning home—she counted all the money she saved and realized that she could not even afford a single way bus ticket. She expected that the classmates from her town could update her on the latest changes in town, but she didn't expect that the news would arrive as a thunderclap in the midst of an ordinary September day.

During lunch, Huai-jin sat amongst her fellow classmates from the same town, but her spirit floated elsewhere, detached from the hum of conversation around the table.

“...that one from Class Yi, remember? She left school in the eighth grade; apparently, she married quite well...”

The mention of a familiar name snagging her drifting attention. Startled, Huai-jin interjected, her voice slicing through the banter, "Who? Who are you all talking about? Who married well?"

“Wang Wo-yu, from our junior high's Class *Yi*.”

“Married? Wo-yu is married? When did this happen?” The questions tumbled out, sharpened by urgency.

One of her classmates, a recent visitor to their county town, chimed in, “It was over the summer break. She had a sizable wedding feast—invited all the local alumni.”

As the news settled over the table, Huai-jin felt it press upon her, heavy and suffocating, like the hot, humid air before a storm. The voices around her buzzed like bees, oblivious to the turmoil unfurling within her.

“...her husband is a soldier, the kind with medals but no taste for academia. He was in search of someone literate to guide his younger siblings. And Wo-yu, she fit the bill.”

“Why didn't he seek someone with a full middle school education?”

“Those with diplomas are few, and those few aspire beyond the constraints of his condition. There aren't many girls with diplomas to begin with, and the ones who have them wouldn't settle for his offer. They're either from good families who can easily find a well-matched partner, or they're striving for their own careers, not willing to be housewives or care for younger siblings.”

“Right, there are three younger siblings in the family. The man's prospects are good, but it's not an easy home to step into.”

Huai-jin's presence at the table became like a ghostly specter, her silence a shroud as she chewed mechanically a world away. The concept of matrimony—a realm so foreign, so deliberately distanced from her own chosen path, had now woven itself into the life of her most important person.

“They do make a fitting couple. To witness them side by side on their wedding day, they complemented each other well. Such a union is rare.”

“Yes, They're well-matched, though. They looked quite the pair at the wedding. It's not easy to find such a match!”

“I heard her elementary school teacher, a military spouse, played matchmaker.”

“That's quite fortunate. Which elementary school was it?”

“In the countryside.”

“Hang on,” a voice cut through, “Huai-jin, isn't that your elementary school as well? And you two were inseparable during your middle school years?”

The mention of her name and her association with Wo-yu anchored Huai-jin back to the present. She lifted her gaze, meeting the collective eyes that had turned to her in anticipation. Her mouth parted for a silent moment before she mustered a voice tinged with an unexpected sharpness, “We've lost contact.”

The words hung heavy, tasting of a bitterness she hadn't acknowledged until they escaped her lips: “As I didn't go back this summer, if you hadn't mentioned it, I wouldn't have known she got married.”

That evening, Huai-jin returned to her student dorm. Recalling what she heard during the lunch, she numbly pinched a half-written letter, unaware of the creases forming under her grip.

She felt she ought to be joyous, yet her heart echoed with emptiness as if a significant piece had been gouged out. For the first time, she truly felt the loss of Wo-yu.

Perhaps the loss had occurred much earlier. Probably she had lost her as early as the day she went to Wo-yu's house to ask about her withdrawal from school and met a decisive rejection. Since then, even in their few encounters, Wo-yu always seemed to dodge her path.

She knew that they weren't ever really each other's only friend. In their first year, Wo-yu had other close friends in her class. Huai-jin knew that after Wo-yu left her, she would surely make new friends—some Huai-jin might know, some she didn't—just as Huai-jin had made new friends after coming to the normal school. Yet, she always held a steadfast belief in her specialness for Wo-yu. Despite the many friends Huai-jin made, none could usurp Wo-yu's place in her heart; and she believed it would be the same for Wo-yu—despite Wo-yu's evasion, it would be hard for Wo-yu to find someone as special as she had been to Huai-jin.

But now, Wo-yu had a husband. He would be the one to walk abreast with Wo-yu through her life. He had the legitimacy, legal bond, daily companionship, and physical intimacy. They were the real family and would have children of their own. Huai-jin's presumed special bond with Wo-yu paled in comparison to such a partner.

Sitting at her desk, Huai-jin covered her face, thinking she might cry; no tears came—yet the ache of wanting to cry without tears was even more agonizing. She asked herself, why am I clinging to Wang Wo-yu, who no longer wishes to communicate with me? It wasn't that she hadn't met others with Wo-yu's gentle demeanor, but that she could never return to being that naive thirteen-year-old, that blank slate of a rural girl; Wo-yu had filled the voids in her existence with friendship, writing down the first words onto the blank pages of her life.

She had known this day would come. They would grow up, each get married, and have their own families. Even if they remained close friends, this day was inevitable. Still, she couldn't ignore the profound sense of loss she felt now. The days of her youth that lingered in her dreams were truly past; the one she had cherished truly belonged to her no more. Wo-yu had grown up, and so must she.

Looking around, she found no more paper. So, she tore off the unwritten half of the current sheet and penned a succinct message.

"Dear Wo-yu," she wrote neatly, in an attitude as formal as possible, "I've heard you're newly wed. I regret missing your wedding. Wishing you happiness in marriage, harmony for a century, everlasting togetherness; may you have a blessed child soon."

This would be the last letter she ever wrote to Wo-yu, she thought.

She would from now on refrain herself from thinking about Wo-yu at all, she thought.

The second year of Teaching School quickly passed.

Huai-jin, during her second summer vacation at the teaching school, did not go home again. She could barely save enough money for a train ticket, but she didn't feel there was a compelling reason to return home anyway, so she spent another summer taking advantage of meals, drinks, and a place to sleep at school. The library was closed, but she had borrowed plenty of books before the vacation, which she could read during the break at her leisure.

When she was enjoying her slow summer, Huai-jin couldn't have imagined that just a few days after school started in September, she would have to take all her belongings to another campus. The province wanted to build more middle schools and urgently needed to train more

middle school teachers, so they temporarily drew students from the teaching schools to run rapid training projects. Huai-jin was selected along with another four students to participate in a rapid training project on Chinese language education at the Northern Campus. The news, dropped in a hushed auditorium, hung heavy over her. At that time, generally, those who taught at middle schools were arts graduates from universities, not specialized normal school students. Huai-jin and others got this opportunity because of their good grades in Chinese, which was indeed a rare chance. However, the announcement, made in the solemnity of an assembly, clung to her like a second skin, tight and suffocating, as this wasn't the life she had sketched out in her mind. In these two years, the southern campus had become her world, but now she was to be uprooted and transplanted to somewhere new without any forewarning. She did have the prior ambition of teaching middle school, but being selected as a back-up teacher basically meant becoming a nomad in the educational system after graduation, filling gaps in distant, undesired locations. The dialogue with her head teacher that followed were a series of well-intentioned conversations aimed at smoothing the edges of this transition. Yet, facing the kind and affable homeroom teacher made Huai-jin even less willing to leave; each word from the teacher felt like a nail in the coffin of her current existence.

The news was announced in the morning, and the departure was in the afternoon. The order of her departure was thrust upon her with a jarring suddenness, leaving her to grapple with a whirlwind of hasty goodbyes. After a quick lunch, her dormitory became a flurry of classmates helping to pack up her sparse belongings. Hugs were given, tears were shed, and wishes to stay connected were made with a desperate intensity. As she stepped onto the bus, the reality of her situation sunk in: a journey to an uncertain future, a leap into the void.

As the bus pulled away, the faces of her friends became a blur, merging with the landscape until they were just part of the view from her window. A pang of nostalgia hit her; she had been here before. In a daze, she seemed to return to the day she left the county town to go to South Normal University. She remembered that morning was cool and moist; there was a light drizzle. That was the first time she had gone somewhere further than the town. Her luggage was just two patched bags and her offer letter. She had four sets of clothes—for all seasons—and the towel Li *Lao-shi* gave her two years ago—and the patched quilt that had been with her since the beginning of her boarding experience. When she boarded the bus and waited for its departure,

she peered through the glass window blurred by rain—she saw someone familiar there, under the roof of the nearby store.

It was Wo-yu, whom she hadn't seen for a while. Before she left the town, she had longed for a final encounter with Wo-yu, to offer a farewell that could seal their chapter together, yet Wo-yu had been avoiding her: she'd even started doing errands on a different day, or had started taking a farther route. But then, it seemed that Wo-yu appeared at the last minute, when Huai-jin had given up expecting her.

Huai-jin didn't see her clearly, nor did she have a chance to confront her. For her whole life she never once had a chance to confirm in person that it was Wo-yu. But at the moment she saw the silhouette, she felt certain it was her. The red shirt and blue skirt—that were her favorite clothes. And she knew that Wo-yu had come for her. Maybe it was narcissistic to feel so—but she felt it strongly.

This ride to the Northern Campus was her second time on a bus. The experiences of these two bus rides turned out to be similar. With the bus's every jolt and turn, memories of Wo-yu, long suppressed amidst the camaraderie of classmates and professors, pushed to the forefront of her mind as a reminder of unresolved sentiments and unfinished stories. After sending the last letter, Huai-jin hadn't thought of Wo-yu so dearly for a while, and whenever she did, she would sternly tell herself that Wo-yu was already married and could not remain the Wo-yu she used to be.

As the bus left the southern campus behind, the bonds she had formed with the people felt ephemeral, tied to a chapter of her life that was closing but not bound to her whole life. She realized that her life had become fragmented. Each segment, each phase, seemed disconnected from the last, a series of islands with no bridge in between. And yet, there was a constant in all this—the specter of Wo-yu—her unresolved past, a thread weaving through her segmented existence, a ghost lingering in the spaces between her new beginnings and her goodbyes.

My Dearest Wo-yu,

I apologize for writing to you again, despite my resolve. After your marriage, I had promised myself not to send any more letters, so as not to disturb your current life. Yet, here I am, unable to refrain. This semester, I arrived at a new, unfamiliar campus—a long story, which I will explain later. During this time, it's not that I haven't spoken to others, but those interactions have been merely functional, necessitated by circumstances rather than a genuine desire to converse—I wonder if you've ever felt this way. Now, I spend my life in a daze, sometimes even questioning my own existence.

My address has changed; I'm no longer at the old campus. I recently wrote to my brothers and family, updating them with my new address. Likewise, I deceive myself into thinking that writing to you is necessary, lest you send a reply to the South Campus. Although I know deep down that a reply is unlikely, should there be even a one in a thousand chance—and you have any response—please send it to this address.

In the first week of the semester, at the South Campus we were summoned to the auditorium one day to hear an announcement. Five of us from our year were selected to join a new short-term training program for teaching Chinese literature at the North Campus. I really didn't want to leave, but all we could do was to follow the assignment. Sadly, the facilities at the North Campus are not as good as those at the South. The campus is smaller, and so are the classrooms and dormitories. A tiny dorm room is crammed with four bunk beds, accommodating eight girls. My roommates all already knew each other, leaving me the newcomer. Even the food in the cafeteria isn't as good. The portion is fixed, barely enough even for a slim girl like me.

Given this intense project, the five of us transferred students feel immense pressure. We used to prepare for various subjects, but not in such a concentrated manner, so it has been difficult to adapt. Our load has increased with several more books on literary history and theory, so we all study desperately, noses buried in books all day. To be honest, aside from studying, I don't know what else to do. I hardly know my classmates, and I'm not familiar with the ones transferred with me. I have nearly no one to talk to. The school does organize activities, though not as many as the South Campus; there are still things like the broadcasting station and the school newspaper. But being new, I'm not given opportunities by classmates or teachers. In any

case, we are so overwhelmed with studying that we have no energy left for other activities. Everyone is so buried in their books, there's no time for socializing.

Especially these past two weeks, Wo-yu, I've felt like a walking corpse, with no energy left for anything beyond eating, sleeping, reading, and memorizing. When I go through the motions each day, I often don't even know what I'm doing. I loathe this state of numbness, but most of the time, I lack the strength to break free from it; and when I do, I feel lost and unmotivated. After much thought, the only thing that seems able to make me feel alive—and that I'm willing to do—is talking to you, even if you never read this letter. I can't discern anything special in my writing, but it's only in conversing with you that I feel my soul exists.

I am sorry, Wo-yu—sorry for intruding upon you once more.

With deepest regards,

Huai-jin

November 7, 1960

February. Despite the fact that the North Campus was still along the southern seaside, winter dominated the land. Indeed, the seaside humidity made the frigidity even worse—the chill, the omnipresent moisture, seemed to be trying to intrude into the human body through every pore.

The night was freezing cold. Huai-jin crawled onto the bed, unsure how many times she had been woken up like this by the cold. Unlike her roommate, Huai-jin had only one thin blanket with patches, which was not enough to cover her whole body. She wore almost everything on her, which kept her a step away from sneezing or coughing but was far from enough to keep her from trembling. After being woken up, she was no longer able to fall back asleep.

The empty beds in the room were reminding Huai-jin how justifiable it was to give up. The roommates who remained all seemed asleep; she could hear their steady breaths and even light snores. With little food and the dark season, every sleep seemed to last till the end of the

world. But at the same time, the cold kept Huai-jin half-sober. In the chilly darkness, a mixed sense of helplessness and loneliness overwhelmed her, which seemed to submerge her into a boundless wasteland where she could see no one and no one could see her. During these hours, her mind was once shrouded in fog, but now, every scattered thought, once disjointed and wild, converged upon her like the looming shadow.

She seesawed between staying and not staying, in one moment vowing to leave and clinging to her school like a vice in the next. The last classmate from her town quit school two days ago. Huai-jin could totally understand it—especially at this freezing moment—the life here was just so hard. She heard that the classmate's brother just got promoted as an officer, so now he had enough connections to place his brother in a mediocre elementary school as a teacher. Had he finished school here, he might eventually have gone to a better school to teach. But it would not make a big difference. Another girl who quit earlier—Huai-jin recalled—her family just arranged a good marriage for her, and her fiancé could easily find her a decent job—maybe not as good as a teacher, but easier too—and her husband would be the main breadwinner anyway.

So they left this hard place. They gave up. So reasonable. But how about her? She had no connections. Upon graduation, the school would assign her a teaching job, and that was the only way she knew she could get a job like this. A step forward, she would be a middle school teacher; a step back, she would be nothing.

She floated in this educated world like duckweed. Her foster family were farmers. Her two biological brothers were on their way struggling for a better life too—they had already done a lot for her and she could not ask for more. If she gave up, she would have nothing. She would return to being a farmer. She would be married to a farmer. The farm would be the beginning and ending of her whole life. All the effort she poured out before this moment, all the loss, all the sacrifice, would become futile, if she couldn't finish these last few steps—the steepest part of the trail.

How did she get here? She had almost used up her two brothers' savings. All of the siblings came from the dirt. They were so disempowered, so insignificant, and so vulnerable in this complicated world, but they tried their best to support each other. While others' brothers could easily find a job for their siblings, her brothers couldn't even help her afford her tuition any more. But she knew that they had given almost all they had. She had not written to them for a

while, but she knew they were all struggling to live, to climb up the social ladder. She could not be the one falling behind.

Chen *Lao-shi* had knocked on her door, opening her path to education, but it was Wo-yu led her to walk far. In the darkness, Huai-jin seemed to see a face emerging in front of her— she suddenly realized again how much she missed Wo-yu. How long had it been since the last time she saw her? After Wo-yu quit school, Huai-jin was, most of the time, just anxious to run into her at all. They did encounter each other a few times, but Wo-yu seemed embarrassed to see her. Even those few times, their greetings to each other were so unnatural. One was pushing. One was evading. Then she left town for the teaching school and never saw Wo-yu again. She wrote so many letters to her but never got a reply.

But...Wo-yu would want her to finish the journey—right? Even if she herself couldn't do it—even if she couldn't witness Huai-jin's accomplishment by her side—she would hope for Huai-jin's success, right? Though Wo-yu never dropped an explicit word—they were then too familiar to do so—but Huai-jin knew that she could understand her. She knew her soul even before she knew her own.

She was already here. She had already gone so far in the journey. There was only a little ways left. If she looked back from where she stood, she had already accomplished so much, right? On her journey, she had walked through most of it with Wo-yu, and then some on her own, and now she was already at the final leg. She hadn't been talking with Wo-yu for a long time, and she was sure to be alone for the rest of the journey, but she had an illusion that Wo-yu was still with her, maybe watching her as a distant star from the sky—so weird to think this way as Wo-yu was still alive—but she did have this feeling. At that moment she felt content. She didn't have a powerful background and connections, but she had Wo-yu, and even if she could only walk with her for part of the journey, it was enough. It was good enough for her.

With her eyes closed, Huai-jin could see Wo-yu as she was that day—when they already broken up into two worlds, yet their worlds weren't so far apart.

She knew Wo-yu had household errands to run every evening, so after school on Friday, Huai-jin penned a request to leave the school to see her family, but in fact, she intercepted Wo-yu on her way home. Wo-yu, basket in hand, paused in barely evident surprise upon seeing her.

"Wo-yu," Huai-jin called to her, and before Wo-yu could even react, she blurted out the whole truth: "The school won't give me a scholarship."

Tears betrayed her, cascading unchecked. In Wo-yu's presence, Huai-jin felt her long-braced armor unravel, daring at last to bare the raw and scarred terrain of her heart.

"The credit union won't grant me a loan, the school won't give me a scholarship."

Through her tear-blurred vision, she sensed Wo-yu drawing closer. A gentle hand rested upon her shoulder. Between sobs, she continued:

"The school won't assist me, won't lend to me. Because of my poor status. But I'm one of the top three."

Wo-yu quietly drew a handkerchief from her cloth bag, dabbing away the tears with a silence that spoke volumes. The handkerchief, tender as a whisper across Huai-jin's face, allowed her to blink clarity back into her eyes.

She saw Wo-yu's eyes—her deep eyes seemed to gleam again with the luster of old days—when Huai-jin felt she could glimpse her own reflection within them.

"It will be alright," Wo-yu murmured softly, "you have worked so hard. You've done so well."

Huai-jin, overcome by her emotions, wept unrestrainedly, embracing Wo-yu in a grasp of desperation. Wo-yu held her, and after a moment, tenderly reciprocated the embrace.

"There will be a way."

At that moment, Huai-jin believed that Wo-yu still preserved a soft heart and empathy for her despite always evading her and trying to act like a stranger to her.

With eyes closed, Huai-jin recalled Wo-yu's visage that day, picturing her standing beneath the evening sun with a gentle hand upon her shoulder. She envisioned the warmth of the sunset, the warmth of Wo-yu.

Upon opening her eyes, Huai-jin felt the long-held back iciness melt down her cheeks.

She cried in the darkness.

She let her tears quietly roll for a while.

“There will be a way,” murmured Huai-jin to herself.

December 24, 1960

Wo-yu, I am writing to you again. But as long as I don't send the letter, it shouldn't count as breaking my promise. Yet, even if it's a broken promise, what does it matter?

We had also made a promise to go to university together and move to a big city. You, perhaps as you said, didn't take that promise seriously; I did, but now it seems I won't be able to go to the big city either. I tried my best, maybe it just wasn't in my fate.

When facing the future, we always dream so easily, overestimating ourselves. But we are always growing, and the world constantly changes, and we will eventually arrive at the point we saw from afar, realizing that we are much smaller than we had thought.

Actually, for a long time last year, I no longer felt the urgent need to write to you. The little details of life, I thought, would be nice to share with you, but it also didn't matter if I couldn't. I got along well with my classmates and teachers, and I gradually accepted the fact that we each have our own lives. Presumptuously, I even felt I didn't need you anymore.

But after being transferred to the Northern Campus, I felt like I was thrown back to square one. I thought about you more often, and you started to reappear in my dreams. I thought I had moved on, but I hadn't. It seems that when the wind is at my back, I can fully immerse myself in my life, but when facing headwinds, I can't help but seek refuge in memories of you. I don't know how to describe my situation. This year has been like a year in the cracks for me; the Past is past—I've already taken a different path from my former classmates. The Present I live in doesn't seem to have accepted me, and the Future has yet to arrive. Now, aside from my exam scores, all I truly have may only be you—though not even the real you, just a projection of memory.

February 27, 1961

Happy Spring Festival. Not sure how it was for you and your family, but no one could properly celebrate this Spring Festival here. After the semester started, the wake-up bell rings every day at noon, and classes don't begin until three. Before class time, the classes take turns in teams to dig up wild vegetables to make into pancakes. During the holidays, it felt merely difficult, but now, as we still have to keep up with our studies, it has gradually become a struggle. It is said we must endure this until the harvest season arrives. Just thinking about it is disheartening.

I miss the Spring Festivals of our childhood that we spent together. The food wasn't great then either—though it was still better than now, at least we could eat our fill. But what mattered more was that life was always filled with hope. Back then, after all, we were just children, we hadn't experienced a better life, and we didn't know what there was to look forward to in the world.

When classes resumed, I found that many people were gone, rumored to have run away. I wonder if they will or even can return. When I was at the South Campus, I couldn't understand why the seniors would drop out so close to graduation. Now, I can understand that feeling. Honestly, Wo-yu, if I were you—I mean, if I were also a kid from the county town, even if parents don't care about their daughters much—I might have gone back too. Marrying someone introduced to me by parents from the town and educating children doesn't seem too bad if it meant I could avoid this hard time; even better if there were a small job.

But I can't do that. I only have a rural household registration, a rich peasant background, no money, and a junior high school education, which is of no use. If I were a boy, maybe I could hope to try to go to the city for high school later on, or make my way by the apprenticeships in the town like my brothers. But as a girl, there are only a few years left for me. After I get married and have children in the countryside, there will be even more to do, and even less hope of studying.

March 4, 1961

My Dearest Wo-yu, I dreamt of you again.

In the dream, you were blurry yet so real. It seemed as if I saw you in a class at the Teaching School, and as soon as it ended, I wanted to talk to you, but you had disappeared. I searched for you all over the school and ended up in our county's middle school. You didn't seem to be avoiding me, but I just couldn't catch up to you. Finally, I grasped your arm, you turned to look at me, and then you said, "I'm gone, I am truly gone."

That sentence struck me to the core. Everything in the dream was unclear, except for that sentence, which I remember vividly. When I woke up, that sentence still echoed in my mind. That afternoon, I was somewhat dazed. On the way to dig wild vegetables, the dream was all I could think about.

I can only see you in my dreams now, only talk to you there. But is the you in my dreams really you?

Wo-yu, it's been three years since I've seen you, and I know nothing of your current situation. The one who speaks to me in my dreams couldn't possibly be the present you. But to say it's the you I once knew—after so many years of separation and the embellishments of memory—your image is probably distorted. As our ancestors said, “What one thinks during the day, one dreams of at night.” Perhaps the you in my dreams is one I've conjured up.

So, what's the difference between the you I write to and the you in my dreams? She is neither the you from three years ago nor the you of now. Who am I writing to, then?

Probably to myself, I guess. Retrospectively, the you I saw worried about what I worried and desired what I desired. All this time, the only constant companion I've had is myself. I've been pouring out my soul to myself; in the process of sorting out my thoughts over and over, it's me who's been listening to myself. When I close my eyes, I see your familiar silhouette, your tranquil eyes, always patiently listening. But I know, that's not you; it's me in a mirror, reflecting your image. Yet, I don't think I can claim that what I imagine is mere illusion either; after all, it is still you, the real you—just the you from the past, the you who was once gentle to me, a projection across the span of time.

Regardless, I'm grateful to you, Wo-yu. Without you, I can't even see myself... another self that could comfort me in the hardest time.

March 19, 1961

Wo-yu, sometimes I am very scared. My periods have become completely irregular now, sometimes painful, and sometimes I'm afraid it will affect my ability to have children later. But I'm not the most unfortunate one. Many of my classmates have developed edema, and recently, another girl stopped menstruating altogether. We give most of the wild vegetables we dig to them, as they need the nutrition the most, but it doesn't seem to help much.

Today, when our class went to pick wild vegetables, I wasn't feeling well and couldn't walk fast, so I lagged behind. Only the party member on duty stayed behind to take care of me; the rest of the students went ahead into the deeper part of the forest. At that moment, I suddenly remembered how you looked when I left you. Perhaps letting you go was the best thing to do anyway. If I were unwell and my classmates still forced me to walk, it would be very painful.

Life is such a lonely journey, and everyone has to have their own.

Ah, to have such wandering thoughts even while struggling to survive, how absurd.

April 8, 1961

As I gradually adapted to my current life, I've started to feel that it's not so unbearable—merely another facet of life I'm accustomed to. I wouldn't say that life now is happy, but rather that I've found a kind of tranquility amidst the suffering, perhaps because I know clearly that there is no way back for me. The sorrow of many classmates comes from their indecision: staying seems painful, but going home seems pitiful. If I don't want to lose everything, I have no choice but to embrace the suffering with simplicity and focus.

When the suffering is mild, I reach out desperately to cling to your ghost, barely afloat; when the suffering is deep, I have no choice but to sink into it, and then I suddenly feel that the suffering is nothing more than itself. Moving across it feels as natural as breathing.

The past me would probably consider the current me to be in misery. And the future me, looking back on these days, might also think it was a time of tribulation. Although I do not feel much right now, I haven't lost the objective realization—our class of almost forty has dwindled to just a dozen due to the harsh conditions here. Everyone's family has some stored grain, and going home at least means no longer worrying about the pressure of studies. Even my rural village—that place of scarcity— has its own rivers and fields.

Now, I don't feel so lonely anymore—perhaps being immersed in suffering has made me less fixated on loneliness, or perhaps it's because my remaining classmates and I have grown closer. After all, those of us who have stayed are somewhat like me, with no way back, and we can sense the similar plight and spirit in each other. When times get tough, we don't even need to talk; a mere glance towards each other provides the strength to persevere.

Wo-yu, if you knew my current situation, you might also feel bitter for me. You were always the one who felt the most pity for me. When I myself was hardly aware of the bitterness, you already empathized deeply with my suffering. But Wo-yu, this bitterness is something I can bear and something I am willing to endure. Wo-yu, do you know the sweetness that comes after persisting through suffering, the taste of freedom from shackles?

But I don't wish to trivialize suffering, nor do I want to glorify it. I am willing to accept suffering, but I would not choose it. I endure suffering now, just so that future me can have more freedom to reject it, so that my descendants won't have to endure similar suffering.

Wo-yu, standing amidst suffering and thinking of you, I feel as if we are people from two different worlds. I remember when we were little and played in the creek—the way I looked at you from underwater—that's how it feels. I used to regret that we could no longer share each other's joys and sorrows. I was sad because I couldn't be by your side to weather the storms, and when I was in pain, I was even more distressed because you couldn't see my pain. But now, seeing the distance between us greater than ever before, I was, surprisingly, not as pathetic as I expected. Honestly, I've imagined if you were here with me at the Teaching School now, facing such difficulties, what would you do — you would go home, right? You have a way out. You are

gentle, sensitive, and you fear suffering. Our starting points were different, and even if we had tried to make the ends the same, because our ways out are different, we would still have parted ways in the end when something unpredictable like this happened. So, our parting of ways was just an early farewell, and it doesn't matter anymore.

Now, more and more I realize that life is indeed a solitary journey... In our village, everyone is born and grows up there, dies and gets buried there, without distinction or separation; but as I step into the larger world, I realize how complex people are, and that being able to walk together for a while is already a great fortune.

Wo-yu, just let me just think of you here, across this distance of suffering.

May 29, 1961

We have just received assignments from the Bureau of Education; I am to teach Chinese at the elementary school on the east side of our county town—the very one that our class leader from Class *Bing* once attended. Since early May, rumors have been circulating that the Provincial Bureau of Education discovered there were not as many middle school students as they had planned for. Consequently, many newly built middle schools were converted back to elementary schools, and it seems that we temporary middle school teachers are likely to be reassigned to teach at elementary schools. Now, at last, the dust has settled.

In truth, teaching at an elementary school is quite agreeable—the salary is not much less. Chinese teachers at middle schools have to instruct students on how to write essays and correct every student's compositions, which is a strenuous task. Elementary school teachers don't need to do that. Although we have studied diligently this year, we have only had one year of training, which is no match for university graduates with degrees in literature; I was very afraid of not being able to provide the students enough support and of leading them astray in Chinese learning. Now, that pressure is gone. With the knowledge we've prepared for middle school teaching, instructing elementary pupils should be well within our capability. Plus, I asked my classmates, and it seems most have been accommodated and assigned their first choice of school.

But Wo-yu, why does my heart still feel an emptiness? Because of this short training course, I left the Southern Campus where I spent two years, along with the teachers and friends I had grown familiar with. This past year, even on days when we were so hungry that we felt dizzy, we still spent time reading. Confronting the complicated books on literary history and theory, we dared not retreat. But now, we're back at the same starting point as all the other students, as if everything we've done was in vain.

I find it very difficult not to question the meaning of this year's training. I am certain I have acquired new knowledge; yet now, I feel it has nowhere to go. One day, I will probably forget it all. Wo-yu, you and I are different... You can leave school with such serenity, pick up your basket, while I detest all things left unfinished, especially those that end without any agency. This conflicted attitude of mine is on the verge of becoming an obsession, likely harmful to my body and mind. Yet, I am not familiar with the counselor here, and I dare not ask for his guidance for fear of being misunderstood as dissatisfied with my job assignment—that would be troublesome. Wo-yu, how I wish to speak with you.

Huai-jin returned to the town after three years with an associate diploma from teaching school. During the next year, she was asked to temporarily take over the Chinese education of a class in a middle school, whose teacher went on maternity leave. She didn't realize, until she said yes to the arrangement, that the middle school was her own alma mater. The last time she was on the campus, she was still a student, lost and baffled about her future, taking the school as her home; this time, she was already a teacher with a foreseeable future trajectory, and meanwhile also a substitute and a guest in the place, facing the young kids with innocent faces, just like her in the past.

There had been no major renovation during these three tough years. She walked through the campus, feeling that everything was just as it was before. She stopped in front of the stairs where she and Wo-yu had encountered each other several times. Remembering that Wo-yu was already on the edge of quitting school then, She tried to recall the exact perspective from which she had seen Wo-yu from the lower staircase.

Everything had changed. The cohort of classmates she once knew had gone their separate ways; some, like Wo-yu, had interrupted their studies to pursue careers, get ready for marriage, or go to the military. Those who had continued their education had since graduated from high school and scattered across the country to attend university.

Huai-jin recalled a classmate from another class who, despite not performing as well academically as her, had managed to secure admission to Peking University, reputedly the best university in China. At this moment, Huai-jin didn't know that many years later, this classmate would become a magistrate. Yet, even now, Huai-jin could tangibly feel that although their lives had briefly intersected, giving her once an illusion that they were similar, their disparate starting points would lead them down vastly different paths.

Thankfully, amidst the changes, most of her teachers were still there. Around the Horticulture Area, Huai-jin met her Junior 3 teacher, Deng *Lao-shi*. He was a bit surprised, but not very much: "I heard that you are teaching in the town. I know you must come visiting sometimes. But I didn't expect you would be back as a teacher."

They chatted, vaguely avoiding what exactly happened during the famine. As Huai-jin mentioned that only one-third of the class made it to the end, Deng *Lao-shi* sighed, "It must be very hard for you. You persisted; that is far from easy." He pointed at the vegetables planted by students, talking about his memory of Huai-jin's diligence in watering the vegetables. "Back then, I could tell from your work ethic that you would become something," said Deng *Lao-shi*.

She would smile shyly. Had she become something? Compared to her past classmates, she was an insignificant being. Of those who had continued their high school education, some went to Beijing and Shanghai, the top universities of the nation. They would become the country's leaders and scientists; some of the luckiest among them would be sponsored by the nation and study abroad. But maybe being a town teacher was already something big for a girl coming from a village.

Now, her monthly salary was 35 yuan, and her room and board was still provided by the government and school for free. That was an amount unimaginable for her in the past, when she was struggling on the semester tuition of only 40 yuan.

She knew she wouldn't want to go far away from home. Her roots were here; she would want to eventually return here anyway. But it was still a hard feeling when she knew that some

possibilities that were never open to her were so easily attainable for others. Wo-yu had failed their childhood promise, maybe she had too.

Huai-jin later visited Li *Lao-shi*, the dear lady who tried her best to support Huai-jin despite administrative punishments. Seeing Huai-jin, she smiled like a chrysanthemum in mid-autumn, which melted the years away, leaving only the pride and happiness of witnessing the growth and achievements of someone she once guided. She took Huai-jin to the class, so she could share her life and study experience with the youngsters. After the class finished, she invited Huai-jin to her apartment for a further chat.

Talking to one of the dearest mentors in her early life, Huai-jin let down her guard, pouring out the questions that had baffled her since she started working.

While her middle school classmates' lives were just beginning, with endless possibilities, for people like Huai-jin it seemed that their generation started to settle. *Da-ge* was just out of nursing school and assigned as a physician for a car factory; *Er-ge* got promoted and started to make his way up the administrative ladder of the prospecting team.

Her own past decade was about climbing up an invisible ladder. She came from the dirt, where everything had defined her—her family, her femininity, her poverty. She had learned to strive, to prove her value to others. But now, her ladder had reached the end. She was forever defined by her current position. What would be the meaning in such a life, a pool of stagnant water without anywhere to go?

“It is a pity, but everyone has their fate. At the end of the day, no fate is superior to the other,” Li *Lao-shi* commented sincerely. “You are at a beginning, not an end. Maybe the decision I made fifteen years ago to become a teacher here was just for the sake of the two years I met you and guided you. I am so fortunate to have ever taught a student like you.”

“Huai-jin,” said Li *Lao-shi*, “I can already see you being a very good teacher.”

In the dormitory, Huai-jin looked out the window, just as the sun was about to set. Ying-zi's words echoed over and over in her mind.

Ying-zi had said that the *Sao-sao*'s name is Wo-yu, although her maiden family always calls her Pan-di.

She said that her *Sao-sao* has already given birth to a daughter, who is two years old this year, named "Li Ruo-zhen," which means "treasured as a precious gem." She told her young siblings-in-law that girls are treasures just like boys. She was now pregnant with another child and, counting the months, was about to give birth. After giving birth and finishing the confinement period, her *Da-ge* and *Da-sao-sao* will come back to show their little nephew and niece to them.

She said that her *Sao-sao* knows a lot, and before the young siblings went to elementary school, she taught them to read, told them stories, and showed them how to calculate. *Sao-sao* was particularly good at math; although she only has a primary school diploma, after *Er-ge* went to middle school, *Sao-sao* could still teach him the math problems that he couldn't solve. *Sao-sao* urged them to study hard and not to waste the nice living conditions they have now. Ying-zi also heard that after *Sao-sao* followed her husband to the military district, under her urging, her husband also went to a literacy class and successfully passed the literacy class examination.

She said that *Sao-sao* had told them Huai-jin's story. She had said that she had good friend who grew up with her, named Huai-jin. She was very good at studying, very hardworking; although she was a girl, her academic performance was better than most boys. She was a girl but strong inside; coming from a poor family, she worked hard by herself, studied hard, found ways to make money and sought support from others to carve out a future for herself. Coming from the countryside, when she first started school, she didn't recognize any characters and couldn't distinguish Arabic numerals, but in the end, she worked hard to get into a teacher training college and soon became a glorious people's teacher, even more outstanding than *Sao-sao*.

She said that everyone in the family liked *Sao-sao* and took her as a role model. She basically raised all these younger brothers and sisters-in-law, and they all listened to her and treated her like a mother and mentor.

Huai-jin had never seen Wo-yu's other young siblings-in-law, but she could tell that Wo-yu taught Ying-zi very well. She would have been able to get into a teaching school too. If she had persisted until graduation, she would also be a teacher by now. She would probably be a

very good teacher. When Li *Lao-shi* said to Huai-jin that she would become an excellent teacher—even before Huai-jin talked to Ying-zi—she thought of Wo-yu.

Wo-yu...who else would be more suitable to be a teacher than Wo-yu? Huai-jin was so touched that Wo-yu had mentioned her to her family with such comments, yet she felt she didn't deserve it. Thinking deeply about Wo-yu made her feel guilt and shame. In her memory, Wo-yu was always understanding, gentle and patient. She always gave, yet seldom asked for anything in return. Wo-yu had shaped her life, yet she could not tell if she had brought anything positive to her. Many years later, when Huai-jin closed her eyes, she could still see the painfully twisted face of Wo-yu that afternoon. The conversation, in fragments, repeatedly came back to her in her dreams. What Wo-yu said lingered in her head, sporadically popped up in her mind. Sometimes she heard, "I am sorry you treated them seriously," sometimes it was a twisted, painful sharp sound—"please stop talking."

For a while, she was afraid that she played a more negative role to Wo-yu, that she had disturbed her life and burdened her with emotion. Her conversation with Ying-zi gave her some relief. Since she is willing to talk about me, she must feel that I was an important part of her past and that I had a positive influence on her life, thought Huai-jin.

The sun started to set. The dust floated in the beams of slightly gilded sunlight like planets in space. Huai-jin remembered those many Fridays when she left school to stop Wo-yu before dusk. She recalled that steaming evening when she was fifteen, as well as Wo-yu's deep, bottomless eyes.

Huai-jin closed the drawer with letters, finally making up her mind. Before she put pen to paper to write a letter, she wanted to take a walk.

After returning to her hometown to teach, Huai-jin seldom ventured far from the dorm. Whether it was the elementary school that she was assigned to or her alma mater where she temporarily filled in to teach Chinese, neither was far from the government-provided dormitory where she resided. The school offered free meals and social activities for teachers, and her dorm

had a supply cooperative downstairs. She essentially moved between two points every day: the school and her dormitory.

The country town of today had grown considerably since her middle school days, undergoing significant changes, despite the three difficult years. Some dilapidated walls had been repainted and adorned with colorful political murals. Streets once paved with stone slabs had been replaced with concrete. Yet, from the contours of the roads, she could still recall their former appearance. As the crisp sound of a bicycle bell rang out, a cyclist passed by her. Without even being aware of it, Huai-jin slowed her steps; the setting sun blinded her eyes, casting her into moments of daze.

She had noticed, as she walked, a new clinic by the roadside, which reminded her of the time when Wo-yu accompanied her to meet her *Da-ge*—what was she feeling then? Back then, she felt like a tiny duckweed; as she didn't want to drift along with the current, she had to desperately seek something to hold onto. During those three years, her education was supported financially by her two brothers, who also visited her from time to time, caring about her studies. Besides Wo-yu, the care and expectations of her brothers were probably her biggest motivation at that time. But eventually they left for their own paths. She still remembered the time when she sat in the auditorium hall with her brothers' letter in hand, numb and lost. That was the first time she truly realized that people met to part, just as they were born to die.

In the sky above the country town, vast swathes of sunset glow burned brilliantly, indistinguishable from the sunsets from the past when she would seek out Wo-yu after school. However, the silhouettes of the buildings under the glorious glow were no longer familiar to her. At this moment, she deeply understood the metaphors she had read in books—how time, like a relentless river, flowed unyieldingly in one direction, sweeping through all in its path, ensuring nothing on the earth remains unchanged. Now back in her hometown—a place where she once more felt like an outsider, just as during her initial days in middle school here—her gripping obsession with the past began to fade, much like ink slowly fading from parchment under the relentless march of time.

Walking slowly along the road, she reminisced about the many people who had crossed paths with her life. She thought of A-Zhang from her family, once her closest childhood friend and sister, who now only nervously and excitedly fidgeted when seeing her. All she could do for

her and the family was to help with some chores when she was home and send a little money after starting her job—only a little, because a teacher's salary, while respectable, was not enough to squander. She remembered Xiu-mei *Jie* from the teacher training college. They had an almost symbiotic relationship, offering each other much convenience in their brief year together. But after leaving the college, Huai-jin's life moved on. While they had promised to keep in touch and write letters, eventually, news from each other ceased. She also recalled her classmates from the Southern teacher school, how she had cried throughout the bus ride as they parted, but she later adapted to life at the northern campus and formed deep friendships during the hardest times; though soon they went their separate ways after graduation.

Throughout her life, Huai-jin met various people, got to know them sincerely, acknowledged their differences calmly, and said goodbye with dignity. There was only one person, entwined with the roots of her being as “Huai-jin” and intertwined with the county town before her eyes.

Having left this town for three years and now returned, Huai-jin still found the path, though renovated, familiar. The people on the street, though strangers, seemed dear to her. In a daze, it was as if she saw Wo-yu, her hair braided with red ribbons, wearing her favorite red shirt and blue skirt, walking on the newly paved road; then, stopping in her tracks, Wo-yu turned her head, smiling at her; the red ribbon in her hair traced a graceful arc through the air with her movement. Huai-jin blinked, and all the illusions vanished, leaving only the sunlit road and the bustling strangers around. In the span of a few breaths, she found her peace, feeling herself slowly embracing the intense feeling and overwhelming memories she had been avoiding since returning to this town.

She had stopped Wo-yu on this road more than once. She had cried, asking why Wo-yu broke their promise, begging her to return; she had thrown letters and class notes into her basket without ever asking if Wo-yu needed them. Wo-yu, more than once, avoided her gaze on this road, but also, more than once, silently but respectfully accepted letters from her. Wo-yu had conversed with her, on this road, with a face devoid of expression and eyes lacking spark, but at times she also gently hugged Huai-jin, wiping away her tears. In Huai-jin's memory, she was passionate, intense, like waves crashing dramatically; Wo-yu was contradictory, silent, passive,

like sketched bits of tenderness at random. Huai-jin thought, maybe, at some point, she no longer understood Wo-yu, nor had she seriously tried to.

Huai-jin arrived in front of a familiar building—the destination of her first visit to the town. Her heart started to beat fast; she seemed to again see Wo-yu's face, all emotions suppressed, as she turned to leave years ago. Approaching, Huai-jin noticed the wooden door looked different, and it was, additionally, now reinforced with an iron gate. She wasn't sure if Wo-yu's parents had renovated or if they had moved, replaced by new residents. She was surprised, but it no longer mattered to her.

Before her, Huai-jin seemed to see Wo-yu as she was in her dreams, saying “I am gone.” To the air, Huai-jin softly whispered:

“Bye.”

She squinted in the sunset, gazing at the town enveloped in golden light. She realized what she wanted to write, as she was ready to know this town again.

She knew what to do.

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